Wadborough Forest

or An Inquiry into the Nature of Value

John-John Markstedt

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"Some people talk to animals. Not many listen though. That's the problem."

- A.A Milne

Part I

On Dreams at the Margin

Deordination

> ”Man selects only for his own good; Nature only for that of the being which she tends.”
>
> - Charles Darwin

The Wadborough forest is a peculiar collection of trees; it’s shaped by an improbable set of circumstances, setting the preconditions of this unlikely tale you’re about to read.

The forest has stood where it now stands for millennia, but surrounded by other trees and part of a much larger forest: it did not crave attention, nor require distinction by name. With the ever increasing sophistication—and population growth—of the main British isle, most trees were cut down for timber, and the woodlands were slowly turned to grazed meadows and tiled farmlands. The trees near the little village of Wadborough would most certainly meet the same fate, if it wasn’t for a growing posh ritual of high British society. The Duke of Worcestershire—lest he lose pace with his peers—began importing pheasants to be hunted by his guests and his more distinguished subjects. He thus proclaimed that the trees near the Wadborough village would never be cut down, and ever solely be allocated to the hunting of game. These trees became

the Wadborough forest—standing tall and alone in the wild ocean of fields.

Pheasants are clumsy birds—used to roam the Asian steps undisturbed by predators—and found it difficult to survive in the forest. To protect their precious game: the Duke's men drove, over the years, all major predators out of the region. The red fox was first to go(to the chickens' rejoice) as they seemed almost offended by the ease of hunting pheasants. The weasel family: the stoat, the wolverine, and the mink; followed shortly thereafter. The badgers were also hunted, but they soon understood that the pheasants were off limit and began to ignore the foreign bird; thus, a few badgers remained alive. As with all human interventions: they're seldom without unforeseen consequences; the rodent population boomed; which, incidentally attracted more birds of prey to the region. These birds—mostly consisting of various hawks and species of owls—did not danger the life of pheasants; however, they possessed another threat entirely. The ornithologists of the time had a fierce reputation of enacting conservation legislation; the rumor of the birds broad prevalence reached the group and soon they took interest in the forest. The Duke thus had a choice: spare the birds and risk the ornithologists' influence, or kill them and risk the outbreak of rodents; he chose the latter. The rodents did explode in numbers, but they did not carry disease with them, nor overrun the neighbouring fields and the Wadborough village. As a matter of fact—the rodents did not at all conform to the behaviours so often attributed to them. No one could explain why.

Eventually the time of serfdom met its end; and the society slowly morphed into something approaching the appearance of a representative democracy. Ownership of land trans-

ferred from lords and ladies to the establish municipalities, and so too did the ownership of the Wadborough forest. Although hunting remains a tradition of the well-off, its clientele slowly shifted to in time mostly consist of ordinary rural villagers. Innovations in agriculture and growing manufacturing greatly shifted the populace from rural to urban. The growing cities lost touch with the rural arts. Hunting—especially when performed as sport as it is with game—became viewed as cruel and barbaric. The urban population greatly outnumbered its rural counterpart in voting power; activists rallied and tallied support—the Bill of The Wildlife Preservation Act soon passed through the county of Worcestershire; which, conveniently holds the legislative power in Wadborough. The Act contained many a paragraph, but only one concerned the Hunters of Wadborough.

> 'A person shall not hunt game birds including but not limited to the Common Pheasant, Grouse, Goose, Turkey, Duck or Pigeon by means of firearm, or any form of projectile, unless bread in captivity under permission from a state licensed breeder(§95b). A person guilty of offense under this Act shall be liable on summary conviction to a fine not exceeding 5.000 pound sterling.'
>
> - §68, The Wildlife Preservation Act

The Act angered the villagers; "what does city folk know of hunting!?" could be heard at the local drinking holes. Wild conspiracies was liberally spread along with wild guesses on the probabilities of actually getting caught. To the villagers dismay, the city clerks had foreseen their unwillingness to abide by the new law and were ruthlessly prepared to hand out many a salted fine during the first year of the bill's passing.

And so it came to be that the forest of Wadborough was free of both predator and man alike—undisturbed by the natural checks and balances that keeps the order of things. Even the locks of gold couldn't compare to the beautiful era that would follow.

♊

Doubt

> "I have never made but one prayer to God, a very short one: Oh Lord, make my enemies ridiculous. And God granted it."
>
> - Voltaire

"One day is today—", Kraerion whispered to himself as his tired eyes slowly widened to an open state. The chimpunk had woke—like all mornings—to a loud unpleasant banging sound, echoing around the run outside the comforts of his small burrow. The sound carried with it the news of a new day, and with it: the message that all who wanted a day's pay ought to drag themselves to the great hall, the Aorta, presently. The frowsty air this deep underground usually made him rise as soon as he woke—to seek a more pleasant ambiance—but today he lingered in thoughts.

"One day is today.", he repeated, to reassure himself and still his doubts, as if repeating the words would make them more true. The power of inertia is strong; Kraerion full well knew of its insidious nature: that tomorrow and never were but equal measurements of eternity. He had longed—even dreamed—for this day to come for as long as he could remem-

ber; so he wondered why—now when the day was finally here—he had so suddenly lost his strong convictions.

Chipmunks may be genetically poised for a life underground, but not the chipmunk Kraerion. Even as a little kitten, he had loathed their exists: the damp runs and burrows, the second-hand air, the ever present darkness, and about everything else underground just by association. He hated—as only an adolescent can hate—that which most of his peers called home. Instead, he wished for a strong wind in his fur, sunlight that uncovered all the beauty that is Nature, but most of all the chaotic buzzing of life above, that so contrasts the routines down below. He yearned to run the branches of trees, not the ever branching network of runs dug in the forest soil. His father had many a time japed that his son was born more a squirrel than chipmunk—and he had not been wrong. When he was younger, he had stated that one day he was going to live amongst the trees, but received feedback which would otherwise only be appropriate after a well executed joke.

Kraerion eventually mustered the will to rise from his moss coated bed. He went over to a corner of his burrow and began scratching away at the dirt.

”Good, still here.”, he confirmed anxiously, as the felt the steel of seven steel screw-nuts—which would surely appear beautiful in the sunlight—laying before him. He covered them up again and left his burrow into the run, and followed its twists and turns until it widened into a great hall: the Aorta. It was dug under a great willow; its massive network of roots—intertwined with the walls and ceiling—supported the weight of the dirt and kept it from caving in.

Since the time of Man, the forest had steadily increased its

economic output. One of the contributing factors was the increased specialization of its inhabitants. Whilst many a specie have some certain advantage in the gathering of some specific type of feed, none is as great a carrier than that of the chipmunk. In their elastic cheeks, they are able to carry loads of feed—and other goods for that matter—efficiently around the forest; their small size and great numbers gave the operation a granularity to it, which made it difficult for larger and stronger animals like the roebuck to compete. When other animals began to hire them for their service, they began to expand their network of tunnels and runs to cover whole forest—connecting all its major hubs. Therefor—every morning—the chipmunks gathered in the Aorta to share news and plan the day ahead.

Most chipmunks were already present when Kraerion entered.

”One day is today.”, he thought again, as he headed towards his usual spot in the front. But he hesitated suddenly and reconsidered; instead, he decided to begin his new life with breaking this habit and found a place in the back.

The murmur of conversation disappeared in an instance when an old chipmunk appeared in the Aorta. His name was Aequitus and was the chief chipmunk, gray spots of fur spoke of his age, yet his features were easy on the eye and he bore his age proudly. Everyone knew the chief and saw him as something akin to a revered hero. When he was but a kitten, he’d taken interest in the chipmunks’ livelihood and noticed irregularities in their billings; after some further deliberation with his friend Br’er Rabbit, he realized that they could likely double their prices with little to no churn. He put forth the motion to the then chief chipmunk, who surprisingly listened

to the youngster and approved it. When their income subsequently increased, he was very vocal about its occurrence, and made it impossible for the chief chipmunk not to pass it forward to the chipmunks' daily wage.

When Aequitus a few years later became unanimously chosen as the next chief, he took it a step further. He transformed the chipmunks' enterprise to a sort of cooperative, with bylaws dictating that a fixed percentage of the total revenue would be earmarked for workers' wages. As well as other rules limiting the influence of his own office—not only for himself but setting the precedence for his eventual replacements.

Together with Br'er Rabbit—who had by then become the implicit leader of the rabbits—and with the help of the by then Glade of Representatives Twig Ongenþeow, he started the Winter Fund. A collective fund that functions similar to that of human insurance: its members contributes feed during the spring, summer, and autumn as a premium; members that find themselves short during the winter may then make a claim and receive feed to sustain them until winter's end.

A cynic human might proclaim the flaw in this scheme, that an animal might take advantage of it by wasting his wage and making a claim every winter—but he forgets two things: most animals can't count; and although possible, making a claim is very stigmatized, and that most animals would rather starve than to broadcast their destitution. Aequitus also—being a co-founder of the fund—made sure that all the work related to the logistics—moving and storing of the feed deep underground, where the soil is grainy, cold, and preserves the feed from pest and rot, and hidden from prying thieves—went to the chipmunks—further boosting the demand for their services.

The fund was a great success; winter deaths decreased drastically the first year, and then slowly year after year. The chipmunks got a more steady stream of sophisticated work from the fund and thus means for a better life. For all the contributions Aequitus made, none could match the feeling he instilled in every chipmunk: the intangible sense of worth; the standing the brought them to in the forest; and the care he fostered between chipmunks by treating them all as equals.

When Aequitus reached the front of the Aorta, he turned and faced the scurry.

"Before we go through today's agenda, I have news—both good and bad.", he began, "And, as you may not be able to appreciate the good in anticipation of bad, I'll begin with the bad.", he took a tactful pause, as anyone with his level of experience would in this situation.

"The eastbound run collapsed late last evening; we're completely cut off from the eastern part of the forest. Therefor, the deliveries to the rabbits' hill must be postponed."

"Why did it collapse?", Aequitus younger brother Pietus asked, who stood at his regular place just right of his brother.

"Well—", Aequitus dragged, "a pheasant went chasing a maggot again and crossed above the shallow no-zone."

"Again!?", Pietus cried, not hiding his contempt, "Did the pheasants not promise to be more careful—that last time would be the last? Will they honour our agreement and pay for the damages?"

"They did indeed. As you all know, the pheasants are not the most organized of animals and will only blame each other if we make a claim for damages. We may bring it to the Glade, but what—other than appearing petty—would we gain? Lit-

tle and less, I'm afraid. Nevertheless, I want you, Pietus, to go to the moles and have them dig a deeper eastbound run this time—that is, at least, a factor we can affect." "I'll do it.", Pietus responded, "But send someone else to the moles next time—they don't even speak our language..."

"Nā, hēo seċġaþ þone ealda sprǣċe. It is we that don't speak theirs.", Aequitus paused, waiting to see if Pietus had a response. When his brother only mumbled something inaudible, he continued.

"I'll make sure Br'er and the rabbits get the news of this postponement personally. As for the good news, the rumors going around are true: the Glade have decided to institute a 2% tax on all Forest shipments. It's only a temporary experiment with us as the pilot service."

"How is this good news?", Veritas squeaked, a tiny runt of a chipmunk who were also standing in the front close to Aequitus.

"Two reasons: firstly, the funds are marked as aid for destitute animals who can't afford the Winter Fund, and we'll surely get the contract for its operation; secondly, we don't pay for our own services—we're essentially exempt!"

"No! That's not how it works.", Veritas snapped angrily, "this will force an increase in our prices—hurt our margins; to only burden one industry, and ours at that—it's... it's incredibly unfair."

"Enough.", Aequitus grumbled, "That's enough, this is neither the place nor time, we may discuss this later in private."

Veritas did not answer, but she turned her head sideways—showing everyone her disdain.

The old chipmunk moved on to the day's normal agenda,

dishing out more routinely orders before dismissing his workforce. However, his eyes were fixed on Kraerion—the dismissal did not apply to him. When the last chipmunk had left the Aorta, he began to speak.

”Kraerion—”, he said.

”Father.”, Kraerion responded, equally enthusiastic.

”It’s true then, hiding in the back like that; you’re actually leaving what we worked so hard to create?”

”What you created you mean? You cannot pretend this is news—I’ve been more than forthcoming with my intention to lead a different life. You of all chipmunks should know of my extra shifts to afford this move, and my refusal of the managerial responsibilities you so blatantly pushed on me.”

”We all have dreams, Kraerion. I know you might *feel* like a squirrel, but you’re not one—I promise you that you’ll end up miserable, dearth of resources, and completely alone in a world of wings if you try to live as one. Dreams are a lesson in growing up: learning how to smother them in favour of what’s truly important in this life. And, you’ll get other dreams—realistic dreams—like forming a family, building a future for our specie, and contributing to the betterment of the Forest at large.”

”I’m sorry—”, Kraerion said at length, ”but that’s not me, and quite frankly, that’ll never be me.”

”Don’t you feel any sense of responsibility? What about your sister Veritas? You expect Pietus and I to go on forever?”

”What about her? She’s smarter than us three combined; she could take over tomorrow if you’d only let her.”

”You know full well that intelligence isn’t everything. You saw how she acted today: she lacks the social conduct to lead other chipmunks.”

”Maybe you should have spoken with her before announcing your decision to the whole Aorta?”

”It’s not only today and you know it. Never mind. If not for us, then what of you and Cinnamon?”

”Don’t”, Kraerion said flustered.

”What, you haven’t told her!?”, Aequitus said truly surprised; he was just about scold his son, but hesitated when he saw Kraerion’s face and realized it would be superfluous. Before he had time to say anything more, Kraerion turned around and ran.

Kraerion ran, and he ran, and he kept on running until the pain in his lungs, and muscles, numbed the thoughts that so rudely had occupied his mind.

Dread

"'Emergencies' have always been the pretext on which the safeguards of individual liberty have eroded."

- Friedrich A. Hayek

Kraerion eventually stopped running; once his emotions cooled off, he felt embarrassed for how he had acted.

"Well, good riddance—", he thought, "at least I can't go back now. One day is truly today."

The chipmunk returned to his burrow one last time, to fetch his screw nuts and say his goodbyes. He had stood there for a very long time; not knowing how to say farewell, and he somehow felt that the moment required a solemn pause. When he made an attempt to leave, his legs refused; he felt an annoyance for his own nostalgia. Life underground was all he had known; nothing would ever be the same.

When he exited the networks of runs through the exit known as the Northwestern Arteriole, a large woodpecker were already waiting for him. His name was Redrill, and he had an especially pronounced red crest. Woodpeckers made excellent woodworkers, but most of them worked in small teams and only took on larger construction projects. But not Redrill,

he was a loner and preferred to work alone and had hence accepted Kraerion's rather unorthodox request. The seven screw-nuts he had fetched were awkwardly wrapped around his front legs, and caught the sunlight and glimmered harmoniously.

"You're really sure about this?", Redrill asked.

"Yes!", Kraerion answered, maybe a bit too quickly, as if he was caught with his paw down a honey pot, "I—I mean, I've never been more sure."

"Don't worry,", Redrill chuckled amused, "I won't argue with the hand that feeds me. I see you've brought payment."

"Well, only one is for you though. Better get going."

The woodpecker smiled, nodded, and unfolded his wings and set off north with Kraerion—with all his might—trying to keep up the pace through the thick undergrowth.

The Wadborough villagers—in a time before environmental concerns—dumped much of their *undesirables* in the forest. Everyone denied it—of course—yet batteries, plastics, electronics, and everything else one can imagine found itself in every nook and cranny of the forest floor. Even a run down car or two occasionally joined the detritus. Most animals—after a good whiff—would not bother with these alien contraptions. But, in a magpie a curiosity grew; soon, he conjectured: these objects of Men may teach a thing or two! The magpie began to take them apart; study their intricate design and their innate structures. He felt an unnatural compulsion towards to the weird family of human fasteners: the screw nuts. Death may be the mother of all beauty, yet these imperishable hexagons of cast steel were of different kind. Sun rays bouncing off their plain silver surfaces caught the magpie

in awe; the beauty consumed him, and he eventually took to hoarding. The desire for these little things spread like wildfire; first amongst the magpies and the other birds in the crow family, but soon all animals had taken a fancy to them—a treasured commodity was born. But it wasn't like any other commodity: it endured where blueberries rot, it was portable where trees stood firm, but most significant was its limited supply—a thing of Man. It couldn't be produced like the spines of a hedgehog's back, nor grown like the acorns of an oak tree. Naturally, the young economy was tired of barter and sought a system to keep better score: an informational instrument to keep track of favours; a fair system of time allocation. And thus, for the first time in the kingdom of animal, go beyond reciprocal altruism—transcend death—and let a money be born.

But to Kraerion, the screw nuts were but a means to an end: to purse life anew.

The day was a beautiful one; the sun shone bright on a blue canvas sky with only a few dots of white. His seven screwnuts around his legs made it difficult to run, and he soon lost sight of Redrill. He did not worry though, the woodpecker would not drop his client for a lousy tempo. His anxious feelings from earlier that morning eased somewhat by the fine weather, like the miraculous cure weather so often can be.

"What a great day!", he said out loud to no one in particular, "What a shame it would be to have it spent underground."

The sun's rays told of high noon, yet the forest was uncharacteristically quiet. Noon was a time of activity, when the animals left their nests, burrows, lairs, and vocational duties to seek out trade. To buy or sell feed; to offer or acquire ser-

vice. Anything imaginable were up for sale: a blackbird could be hired to sing, a joyride could be enjoyed from the back of a magpie, fresh blueberries—or stolen cabbage from the neighbouring fields—could be bought. Therefor, on any other day, a distant voice in his ears would not have sparked his curiousness. When he reached a clearing in the trees, he leaned back on his hind legs and saw—past the overgrowth—a hedgehog and a robin arguing intensely. He recognized the hedgehog as a acquaintance of his fathers, he knew him as Spinestack, and closed the distance to them.

"Are you mad?", the robin asked flustered, "Have you completely lost your mind? You know I need more than two measly spines."

"Spines are not weeds you simply pluck from a field of your choosing; they take effort and care to grow.", Spinestack answered calmly, "And these recent—although tragic—events have created a wonderful demand, as you surely understand."

"But... But that's more than trice as expensive than just a couple weeks ago. This is war profiteering! I'm down to my last screw nut; you must understand."

"I mustn't anything.", Spinestack reassured calmly as he saw Kraerion approaching and waved, "I could ask any of your neighbours, who, I'm sure, would find the price both fair and appropriate."

"Wait, hold on,", Kraerion interrupted as he took notice of the small heap of spines, sharp and keen, laying between the two animals, "What do you mean war? And what on earth would you need spines for?"

"Oh haven't you heard!?", the robin squeaked, "It's terrible—*Terr-i-ble* I say: just this morning a nightingale in the same tree as me got her screw nuts stolen. And it's not an isolated inci-

dent either, it has happened all over the forest in the last few days. I refuse to sit idle by; we must take up arms and defend ourselves—just like in the tales of the time of Man!"

"Hrmf", Redrill uttered from a twig above the group, seemingly appearing from nowhere, "I heard a few rats have similar complaints earlier this morning, apparently a few of their burrows had been raided. And they are *rats* after all, who dares mess with them?"

"Yes, very sad indeed. Now could you take your discourse elsewhere?", Spinestack said, glaring at the two newcomers, "We are conducting serious business here, go waste someone else's time—preferably someone whose time is of less value than mine."

Redrill gave Spinestack a sharp look of disgust, "You've always been more heap than stack, don't you think?", he jested, untucked his wings, and took off. Kraerion had not much choice but to follow.

When they reached the silver birch—which was to become Kraerion's home—a fluffy wood pigeon greeted them with a coo.

"Welcome Kraerion, to our humble and peaceful corner of the Forest.", the pigeon said. His name was Greyhead; this pigeon landlord owned a score of birches and had agree to sell part of one to Kraerion. It was very unusual for one animal to only own part of a tree; most animals paid rent. Kraerion had first been offered to rent, but refused—he was ready for a life free from the burden of economic dependence and thus the need of a steady wage.

"The meter directly above the first twig is yours. I've etched in some markings, you may, of course, measure it yourself."

Kraerion nodded and handed over three of the screw nuts to Greyhead. The pigeon thanked, and having errands elsewhere—excused himself and flew away.

Redrill had received instructions many days ago, and wasted no time consulting Kraerion on what to do. He flew up and landed on the south facing side of the birch and began drilling. The woodpecker's head jerked back and forth, transforming his appearance into a red smear. Kraerion felt very silly when the origins of Redrill's name suddenly dawned on him, he could not believe how he hadn't realized it sooner.

Woodpeckers were not made to carve homes in the trunks of trees. Their strong chisel-like bill and shock-resistant head had slowly been selected by Nature for its ever increasing ability to prey on termites, beetles, and various other larvae dwelling behind bark and wood. But—like most animals—with the rise of a market, their abilities found a vastly greater commercial value elsewhere. And, the woodpeckers found it in carpentry.

Kraerion didn't know how to act whilst Redrill worked. He felt that he would only be in the way if he tried to help, and there was nothing else there he could occupy himself with. He had not stood there long before he was saved by a loud screech from a neighbouring birch.

"Wait here.", Redrill yelled urgingly from up above; he dashed—without hesitation—towards the sound. Kraerion paid no heed; instead, he lunged to the tree and rushed up its trunk. The trunk divided evenly into three large limbs; between them lay a pigeon's nest. He continued up one of the limbs as to look down and see it. Redrill was perched on a branch opposite of Kraerion—they were the first on site. And as pigeons came flying from all directions, they looked down

and saw a terrified mother and her three newborn squabs, naked save for their scrawny, near undeveloped down.

”They’re gone;”, she said despondently, ”They’re all gone. Oh dear, how will we survive?”

”Won’t nest insurance cover it?”, a pigeon asked after a long moment of silence.

”No,”, another pigeon answered, ”theft has not been an issue since the time of Man. Why would anyone even think of including it in coverage?”

”It may yet be rectified, as far as I’m aware, nest insurance has always been implied to cover these kinds of things. I’m sure there’s some broad clauses in there that might be stretched to cover this situation.”, Greyhead broke in, sighed, ”Otherwise, we’ll come together and cover it ourselves; solidarity is not yet lost on us. Regardless, the best we can do for now is to give her some room and time to breath, especially by those not yet part of our community.”

The insinuation was not lost on either Redrill or Kraerion. Nevertheless, it was a reasonably request, and the two animals vacated the tree.

”We’re not particularly popular today.”, Redrill muttered jokingly.

The moon had long since appeared when Redrill finished his work. The woodpecker sailed down to Kraerion at the foot of the birch.

”I guess I’m done!”, he proclaimed, ”Are you sure it’s deep enough? It’s barely more than an entrance.”

”Well, you know I can’t afford more of your time.”, Kraerion answered. ”Besides, me teeth should be strong enough to carve out the rest. Take the screw nut before I regret it.”

As he handed over one of his screw nuts to the bird, Greyhead appeared again.

”Good evening, excuse my rude remark earlier,” the pigeon began, ”these are strange times; I hope you don’t take it as a reflection of your person.”

”No offense taken.”, Redrill said whilst Kraerion simply nodded.

”I have some news that might not have reached the two of you yet.”, Greyhead continued, ”The crows have called for a state of emergency, there’s going to be a meeting in the Glade, tomorrow at noon. Thought you’d like to know.”

”Okay, thanks.”, Redrill said tiredly, yawned, and turned to Kraerion, ”It’s getting late, are you sleeping here?”

”Not like I have a choice, the new tenants have most likely already moved in to my old burrow.”

”Well then,”, the woodpecker said and untucked his wings, prompting Greyhead to do the same. The two birds took off and disappeared into the blissful summer night. Kraerion was left alone with his hollow, his new life, and his ever intruding thoughts. Still unsure if he had made the right decision, he climbed up the tree to his entrance.

”One day was today.”, he concluded solemnly. The hollow’s floor was still rough and unyielding, but it wasn’t the brown soil of a burrow—that was all that mattered. With time, he would widen the hollow, grind the walls and floor sleek, carry up moss and lichen to make a bed, and slowly be able to call it home. That night, he slept uneasy; his body and limbs were heavy and exhausted, yet his mind was unbridled and completely awake. When sleep finally came, it was with an unusual satisfaction that only major life decisions produces—it scared him to know that he’d almost gone a whole life with-

out it.

Deputation

"the only thing we have to fear is fear itself."

- Franklin D. Roosevelt

The crows watched as the animals poured into the glade—the Glade of Representatives. The murder sat comfortably tucked all along the branches of the ever reaching crown of the Old Oak. From afar it looked as if the Oak bore large, black acorns. Since the time of Man, the animals had gathered here to discuss public matters, to air opinions, and to converge on decisions. Although the glade bore a suggestive name, it wasn't a republic in the most human sense of the word. It wasn't a selected office: no animal spoke for a predefined set of members; instead, non present members usually had someone whom they trusted there, who could speak on their behalf if needed. In fact, the meetings in the Glade was open to everyone; and anyone who wished to speak could. The animal species differed widely in their eagerness to follow and participate in the discourse. Many of the crows and the rabbits were actively engaged in the discussions, and the presiding officer—responsible for the agenda and order—had been a crow for generations, and became referred to as the Twig. The rats and

the blackbirds on the other hand, took little to no interest in the proceedings. The pheasants did not even attend; their concerns were more of worms, than with words.

Kraerion entered the Glade when it was almost full and opted—in the spirits of his now arboreal life—to join the birds amongst the trees. He was taken aback by the might of the Old Oak—its powerful branches and colourful leaves seemed as powerful and green as ever. As he found a comfy twig in a beech, he saw Aequitus and Pietus standing next to the rabbits; and his heart dropped. He felt at once uneasy. He knew he'd done nothing wrong by leaving, yet his body felt otherwise.

When the last roebuck straggled into the glade, a crow signaled for them to start. The crow took a few awkward skips out on the oak branch, so as to be seen by all. He bore the name Eaglewing. His right wing was unevenly discoloured: half the wing's feathers were of a peculiar colour of brown, not unlike the wings of an eagle. He had been an unlikely candidate to the office of Twig; although, he was the son of the previous one, Ongenþeow, but been born very much the runt of the litter. His discoloured wing was also rumored to be broken, and only a few crows could claim to have seen him fly. The crow began to speak:

> "I am not the fool to deny, nor delay, the pretext by which we have so promptly gathered here today. It is ever so important—in times like these—to be blunt: attack the issue unto us—with naught but truth—frankly and boldly.
>
> But first, fellow Animals, I would like to say this: it is in difficult times we get to show what we have been

made of—our true colours and morals. And I am certain, our colours shall burn true and its brightness prevail! Our Forest shall endure, as it always hath endured: since the time of Man and the founding of this very Glade. I promise ye, we shall—once again—unite against our common foe, and earn a second wind with this imminent victory!

If thou hast lost thy screw nuts, dost not worry; dost not attempt revenge—or any other folly—by thyself. Thou shalt be revenged—in Time—by a collective effort. I hold the firm belief that the fear itself is more dangerous than what we fear—wicked, dark, unsettling terror that have paralyzed every important function of our Forest. A few stolen screw nuts in themselves: are insignificant in the greater scheme of things; an empty forest, a lack of trade, a hoarding of goods, a canceling of service, and an arming and guarding of thine own: are significant. Our beloved Forest hath reached a complete standstill in the fear of theft; it ought to fear the lack of feed come winter. Fear of trade undealt. We have retreated back into our humble nests and spartan burrows; now we must advance with full force! Our Forest asketh for action, and action thou must allow us to take.

We may wage war against this unknown perpetrator: a war of suspicion with accusation as ammunition. Or we may not. Even a victorious battle against this enemy amongst us may lead us unto defeat—the loss of Time; to while whilst winter marcheth.

In policy—as in life—it is difficult to seeth but the short term. To value tactic over strategy. Doth catching our foe red-handed—spending all our time and resources in the process—prevent any future crisis of this kind? Our reforms must gain strength from our

> history and turmoil; they must adapt from our scar-tissue, and our Forest evolveth by it.
>
> It saddens me to acknowledge: this Glade is not prepared for this challenge. It's in a sad state indeed. It's currently but a mere group of volunteers!
> It hath no funds to relieve its victims.
> It hath no office to investigate this matter.
> And, —
> it hath no mandate to prevent this—nor anything of equal weight—to happen in the future.
>
> Our Forest hath grown, but our Glade hath not grown with it, and that must be set right now. We are prepared to exhaust our full arsenal to meet this crisis. To go beyond what hath seen constitutional—and deemed reasonable—in the past. Our first step, thou wilt shortly learn from Hroðulf, yet that is but a beginning. So, I ask this Glade—and its Animals within it—for this final instrument to face this challenge—broad executive power, to wage a war with this crisis, the power that would be given unto me if our Forest was indeed invaded by Man once again."

The glade was in silence when Eaglewing receded backwards on the Oak branch—leaving room for Hroðulf—who quickly took his place. Whereas Eaglewing spoke with a confident, well-paced certainty, never missing an emphasis; Hroðulf spoke with a twitchy, irregular pitch, as if he never given the spoken word a forethought. The crow with his two perfectly black pair of wings was renowned for his wit, yet was somehow very unpopular with the rest of the animals.

"There was once a man who proclaimed: incentives trump ethics every time.", Hroðulf began, "And we're not even Men; Men are creatures of sin, the only specie known capable of

doing harm without direct benefit to his person—truly the purest form of evil. Us Animals are simpler: we're not driven by hate nor envy. Remove the incentives and you remove the act itself."

Hroðulf took a pause. He didn't lack confidence nor certainty in his message, but he lacked confidence however—especially in the aggregate—in the animals' intellectual abilities. He knew he had to go slow, never leaving out a simple deduction of reason.

"If we remove the incentives for thievery, we remove thievery itself.", he repeated thus, "The thief steals only with the prospect of spending his spoils in the future; but what if what he has stolen could be rendered unspendable? Theft would be moot to him. Our screw nuts—which undoubtedly contains a diverse set of colour and shape—are still too fungible to trace with any certainty. We can't efficiently tell them apart; we can't ban a particular stolen screw nut from ever being spent. Fungibility is certainly an admirable quality, but it and traceability are not necessarily contradictory traits; on the contrary, a traceable mark issued by the Glade could only serve as a valid baseline for the fungible unit itself. If an unique mark was inscribed on our screw nuts, and remarked before stolen: spending it would accomplish naught save the admission of guilt."

The crow took another pause, he knew his finale could create controversy and he made sure to get every word correct.

"There is however, no way to mark the screw nuts themselves; but, we can mark leaves. We suggest that the Glade temporarily issues leaves in place of our screw nuts, until this wave of crime calms down."

"I'm not sure I understand", Br'r Rabbit said after a moment of silence, "You want us to replace our screw nuts with

leaves? But leaves are everywhere—you could just pick them up?"

"The leaves will be but a certificate of ownership of the real screw nut. The leaves will have an unique sequence directly corresponding to a screw nut safely stored elsewhere. The quantity will thus remain the same: one screw nut, one leaf."

"But, could you not simply copy the sequence, and spend it twice?"

"Yes, if not for our new secret process to fortify them, effectively making the leaves impossible to counterfeit."

"Do I need to remind you all that leaves have a tendency to rot!?", a new voice bellowed from the far end of the glade. It belonged to Αίσωπος, the forest's last remaining badger. He emerged from the crowd and headed towards the center of the glade, and with him followed a strong, foul smell. The animals he passed jerked away from him; they did so however, more out of reflex than actual disgust.

"No, thou dost not." Eaglewing responded before Hroðulf had a chance to, "Thy apprehension saddeneth me. In the same process where we make the leaves counterfeit proof, a silkworm addeth a thin, almost transparent hue around the leaf: protecting it from wear, tear, and as thou hast so kindly contributed: rot."

"All but a gullible disposition would sadden you, I'm sure.", Αίσωπος roared, "This plan has so many flaws, where do I even begin...Let's begin with this: how can we be sure that the amount of leaves remain at a one-to-one ratio with the screw nuts?"

"Before I respond to these ridiculous questions of poor judgment, let me remind ye that Αίσωπος is not your friend: he might have some ulterior motive with these questions—

maybe his interests align with letting this issue remain unresolved. Nevertheless, I shall address every rabbit of straw thou callest forth.", Eaglewing took a deep pause, showing off a sly grin, as if he had waited for exactly this moment, "We shall arrange regular audits of the amount of screw nuts in custody; as frequent as to give no doubt of any discrepancy."

"How shall the screw nuts be protected? To whom shall this significant burden fall upon? Perhaps this might be what the thief—who you ascribe so much influence—wants? Now they'll be gathered together in one place—one massive pot of honey."

"We did not intend to disclose our plan to guard the screw nuts today. But, as a gesture...", Eaglewing didn't get further before being cut of by Αίσωπος.

"See Animals, as always these crows only reveal what suits them for the moment! I categorically doubt their competence to implement this scheme, but I doubt even more their reasons to go through all this trouble! The screw nut have served our Forest well; a guide towards efficiency, a creator of wealth. The screw nuts became the means of exchange not by decree, but by an organic force of Nature. And, who are we to intervene with forces we do not understand? And, who are you, Eaglewing, to conspire against us and Nature herself?"

"But, as a gesture...!", Eaglewing repeated louder than before, "of good faith: I will tell thee now. A few days ago, a few crows found a litter of stoat kittens—clearly abandoned by their mother—as they flew over a neighbouring meadow. They be but blind and furless; their Animal still plastic, unformed by their natural instincts. We will raise them with a singular purpose: to guard and protect the screw nuts—with their life if necessary. And, let me answer thy incomprehensi-

ble drivel about Nature with a question: Whence came that peculiar odor of thine, if not from Nature herself?"

"Ssss—Stoats!?", Br'er Rabbit shrieked, trembling like a shackled leaf on the wind, "I—I must have mistaken, did—did you say stoats?"

"You crows have gone completely mad!", Αίσωπος thundered as he stormed off, "I will have no further part in this folly."

"Yes..., stoats", Eaglewing almost whispered in contrast, "But dost not worry Br'er Rabbit, we're long past the days of predation. I promise thee: they shall conform to our ways of life and abide by our laws—I shall make that my personal mission. If anyone doth not object to the idea, of course?"

The question silenced the glade, yet the air told of unrest. Even though no animal in the glade had been alive in a time of predation, many of them still felt like pray; the innate: that which no constitution, nor glade, can amend. No one spoke, not necessarily due to cowardice, but rather due to the limited time to come up with a reasonable objection. Br'er Rabbit opened his mouth, but spoke in Silence. The beautiful language of Nature, but also the language with a thousand ways to say what you later come to regret. The moment passed, Br'er Rabbit had not said a word—yet everyone had heard what he said.

"Good.", Eaglewing concluded, ignoring the silence, "It's decided. We are done here."

The forest had not—since inception—been without a guide. First, of course, it was aided by the laws of physics; thence, by the rules so elegantly described by Darwin; and eventually, by a certain hand which could not be seen. That hand was now

feathered and coloured black, and it would remain visible—irreversibly—forevermore.

Delight

> "If a man does not keep pace with his companions, perhaps it is because he hears a different drummer. Let him step to the music he hears, however measured or far away."
>
> - Henry David Thoreau

The sun slowly rose in the eastern sky; innocent rays of morning trickled through the dense forest canopy. The sparse beams reaching for the undergrowth, fighting off the morning mist like a potent antidote. The daily struggle between dew and vapor began anew. Kraerion sat awake in his hollow, hunched on his forepaws, gazing contently out through the morning air. He had woke—like most mornings—to the varied orchestra of nightingales and blackbirds, tirelessly competing for the vibrations of the humid air. The beautiful song was now and then disrupted by the distinct cooing of one of the neighbouring wood pigeons.

Kraerion had managed well: gathering his own feed, supplemented by the odd job here and there when such opportunities arose; but—of course—he was less efficient now then when he was gainfully employed. Yet, he enjoyed his new savage life, what he lost in produce, he gained in beauty. The

absence of the natural irregularities of life—which a steady piece of produce, from an even steadier wage, had smoothed numb—was to him by itself: disutility. And, waking before the sun instead of with it—there's disutility there too.

Before he left his burrow and former life, he had saved for a long time. He had manage to obtain his small fortune of seven screw nuts by sheer hard work; three for the birch, one for Redrill, and the three remaining to act as a safety net during the transition to independence, and to cover any unforeseen uncertainty that his new life surely could entail.

But, that summer, he was blessed with something magical: prices began to fall. First little by little, and then all at once. By the time the sun reached its summer solstice, the prices had dropped to about half of what they had been during the spring—making his savings not only ample for his transition, but ample for anything the future could possibly bring.

No cause could be attributed to the sudden drop in prices, but thought or concern did not burden the Wadborough animals; instead, they feasted as if the abundance of summer would never deplete.

The exchange to leaves had happened as the Eaglewing had dictated exactly one week after the meeting in the glade. The animals had formed a queue before the Old Oak, to attempt an orderly, pedestrian proceeding. Although the animals had increased in affluence, queues are still as innate to them as a sheep stalking a pack of wolves, or a chicken snagging a fox for dinner; thus, it was short of a miracle that no major incident occurred. Kraerion—ever so careful—had waited until the absolute end to avoid most of the expected tumult before exchanging his remaining screw nuts for a thin stack of leaves.

A sound of scratched bark broke his thoughts. As so often happened to Kraerion, his thoughts remained but half processed—he was flung back to reality with a mind in an unfit state. He leaned his head out of his hallow to see down the trunk and saw a familiar shape standing at the foot of his birch.

”I’m not climbing this *thing*!”, Cinnamon cried mockingly. Kraerion moved—in response—down the tree and stopped a rought meter from the ground, in a manner not dissimilar to that of a nuthatch.

”You never said goodbye.”, she said at length when Kraerion failed to speak.

”What could I have said?”, he answered, knowing full well how stupid it sounded, ”Besides, I don’t think I could—it was difficult enough as it was.”

”Well, if it was too difficult—might it not be the wrong decision?”

”No!”, he cried harshly as by reflex, ”It was truly the best decision I’ve ever made.” As usual, he spoke before thinking and missed to consider the product of his words—now Cinnamon looked rather hurt.

”I miss you.”, he added quickly, ”You know what I mean. You know how miserable I was; I wouldn’t have been good for you or for anyone if I had stayed.”

”I guess you’re right.”, she whispered, mulling it over.

”Do you want to walk somewhere?”, he asked, more to get out of the awkward silence than anything else.

”Somewhere?”

”Anywhere.”

”And here I thought you were the one to distinct between walk and wander; but sure, we can walk.” she remarked, mak-

ing something that could be construed as a smile, before turning. She began walking eastward, before he had a chance to reply and he was thus left with no choice but to follow and catch up with her.

Kraerion had long made an effort to distinguish between walking and wandering. ”Walking is active and with purpose—you *walk* with the purpose to get somewhere.”, he would preach, ”But wandering *is* the purpose, done for its own sake—an end in itself.” To Kraerion they were more than just definitions, they symbolized the two different outlooks of life: the former, the ambitious numbness of habit; the latter, the very beauty of life itself. He reasoned that ones quality of life could be deduced from this innocent choice of words. That someone who walk instead of wander, would eventually met with the Thoreauvian fear: to wake up one day and discover they had not lived. The chipmunks—and thus also Cinnamon—had built their existence around transportation, schedules, and habit; so, whilst she would always listen, he feared she would never truly hear.

After wandering for some time, Cinnamon broke the silence.

”I’m worried about your sister,”, she began tentatively, ”she’s changed.”

”Veritas?”, Kraerion said.

”I... — I don’t know. Well, maybe not changed per se. She’s herself alright, only more so.”

”Honesty, can you too much of that?”, Kraerion chuckled, ”I think I see what you mean though. She can get stuck in her mind sometimes, not letting thoughts go—like caught

in a never ending loop. But she's sharp, I'm sure she'll figure it out."

"I don't know, maybe...", she said slowly, "Maybe that's why we call someone smart sharp, they cut wherever they turn—themselves too if not supervised. Whilst, someone dull couldn't hurt a fly if they tried. But you know what Kraerion, you were always her whetstone; always there to keep her on track. And well, you're not there anymore..."

"Nonsense, you talk as if she's crazy!"

"Maybe she is! She's at least beginning to be perceived as if she is. But, there's more, she's started talking about our economy as if there's some great danger to it. She's not terribly coherent in the best of times, but now she's regressed to repeating...—repeating these incomprehensible phrases."

"What do you mean phrases—what phrases?"

"There's a bunch of them, but there's a couple in particular that she keeps repeating which I managed to remember: 'feed is dialectic; hunger is constant', and 'The delta must eventually reverse'", she paused, "Do they tell you anything?"

"Well...", he thought for a while, "The first is clearly about winter. Feed is cyclical: from the first rare morels that nigh beat thaw, to the late autumn tubers that's accessible until the ground freezes. And, hunger is..., well hunger: constant and independent of season. But why would she bring it up now? That's always been the case, and the Winter Fund was invented to fix it. She's *practically* running the fund now, in all but name.", he took another pause, "the other one I don't understand though."

Their conversation did not end, but transposed to one in Silence. With words omitted, they traversed through the forest. Animals communicates more with their bodies than

humans, and the two chipmunks soon fell into the comforts they so many times before had felt in each others presence. Nevertheless, there was much left unsaid between them and a tension slowly grew. Cinnamon had not shown up but for a sense of duty: to tell of Veritas well-being; both knew it, yet they left it unresolved.

"You are never coming back, are you Kraerion?", she said when she finally had had enough of the silence, stopping abruptly, her two chipmunk eyes—glimmering, like black pearls caught in sunlight—glaring straight through him.

"No.", he said staunchly after some thought, "I'm sorry, but I don't think I ever will."

"But why—why would you leave? I'm not asking for Veritas, or Aequitus, or anyone else; I'm asking for me, Kraerion. For me. What about us—what about the life we were creating?"

"I don't know what more I can say...", he said sadly, "I can explain how awful I find life in darkness with that damnable filthy soil all around, how it's like my body completely rejects it; as you seem to reject the notion to live in the trees. No matter how much I want to be with you, I can never be in consonance with a life underground. I assure you, it hurts me as much I think it hurts you, to not see you everyday."

Once again, they regressed to Silence. Exhausted by their imposition, they wandered along.

They wandered past the rabbits' great hill, thence past the clearings which constitute the central parts of the forest. Many an animal laid leisurely basking in the morning sun, and they watched as the two chipmunks quietly wandered past. "That's queer,", Kraerion thought, "aren't they suppose to be working at this hour?", but he soon dismissed the thought.

When they reached the Glade of Representatives. Kraerion could scarcely recognize the glade without it being filled by the forest's animals. The glade however, wasn't empty; on the contrary, woodpeckers were swarming the Old Oak—pecking away at its trunk; sturdy roebucks were hauling loads of dirt away from the glade; and, crows were all around, talking amongst themselves—making plans.

They had nigh entered the glade before a voice called out for them.

"Good morning!", the voice cried, which they now saw belonged to Hroðulf, as he waved them to come over. He was standing next to a straight stick standing perpendicular to the ground; stones had been laid out around the stick to form a semi-circle. In between every stone, lay a couple of couple of pebbles.

"Morning,", Cinnamon responded as they approached, "What is this?", she continued as she pointed at the stick and stones. Hroðulf only smiled for a while, then he spoke:

Our sun, eternal bound,
Alone she goes around;
Her shackles that of natural law,
Yet she smiles; and thy bones thaw.

And trees the east salute,
To whom that bears them fruit.
Although raised in different glades,
They cast but similar shades.

What an angle may disclose,
To thee, and she who knows;

With stick and stones to be precise,
Of where a shadow's bound to slice.

Our sun, eternal bound,
To us distant yet profound—
To tell the pace of the Sublime,
And thus thou know about the Time.

Just when he stopped talking—as by a bespoke request to God—the sun appeared behind the lone cloud in the sky. Its rays of sunlight gave birth to a shadow running from the stick to the second westernmost stone.

"Wait—", Cinnamon said astonished, "do you mean that this thing—this *contraption*—tell us the time?"

"Yes!", the crow hooted with delight, "And here I thought *rodents* were void of wit! Whilst the sun travels above us from east to west, its shadows travels from west to east. The stones simply enumerates the Time of day."

"And this shadow, is it precise?", Cinnamon asked, ignoring the slight, "Is it at the same stone at the same time every day?"

"Not only is it precise, it's also completely independent of location. No matter where in the forest, the angle of the shadow is exactly the same. We can just raise the same structure in all parts of our Forest, which I presume you chipmunks—with your vocation—see the value in."

"This is truly *brilliant*, nothing will be the same!"

"No, this in nothing. It's a simple iterative improvement.", Hroðulf concluded, albeit with a tone free of humility, his smile from before appeared again as he considered if he ought

to say what he was thinking. His urge to tell won over his prudence to keep shut:

"But I will tell you what is: sentiment. There are so many of these silly believes that by themselves becomes the agents of its own truth. For us, as individuals, spending less than we earn is the only viable strategy for long-term wealth; hence, it's thus assumed, that the same strategy ought to be applied at the aggregate level of total spending, and spending regarding the public. Naught could be further from the truth! What's true in the singular, might be the complete opposite in the aggregate.

Consider for example: if each animal saves more, then each business would receive less and subsequently have less to pay out in wages or earnings, which in turn would only decrease what each animal have to spend in the first place. Good individual decisions could thus cause a vicious spiral of less and less spending rendering a huge dent in our economy. Frugality would make us all the poorer!

Savings bear no meaning in its aggregate, if you really think about it. If someone reduces his savings by way of consumption, it will become but the savings of someone else. Aggregate savings must always equal the total supply of money.

And, that leaves us with sentiment. It has been shown that animals saves less if they believe in a strong economy; and more for a weak one. How backwards is it that our economy is at the whim of fools' belief! What if I told you, there might be other ways for us to control demand?"

When Cinnamon responded to Hroðulf's conjectures, Kraerion

had long stopped to listen. ”The need to know the Time *is* the problem.”, he muttered, ”No one makes plans to smell the hillside flowers, nor watch the glimmer of the morning dew; when the day’s activities becomes shackled to Time, the wonders of the world does not cease to exist, but becomes imperceptible with no Time available to stumble upon them. The solution to Time, is indeed no solution at all.”.

Instead, he chipmunk admired the woodpeckers hard work. He was hit by sudden realization: weren’t there too many a woodpecker for just one tree; and the roebucks were hauling dirt, but there was no sign of digging—whence came the dirt? But, what did Kraerion know about the process of industry; a subject he had so eagerly ignored to understand.

When great ideas are discovered—those seemingly obvious in hindsight—they appear imperishable. There’s no way to put the genie back in the bottle. They propagate from mind to mind—like a virus—only by the perceived virtue of the idea itself, until it’s safely kept in the collective mind of society. Yet great ideas do perish; they slowly change, transforms, and morphs until it’s something completely new and nothing of its original beauty remains.

We humans of today have learned to tell time in base 60, because long ago, when the ancient Babylonians created their first sundial they had in turn inherited a sexagesimal system from the even more ancient Sumer. Much of the meaning, its innate substance, of their system of mathematics have long been forgotten—or fallen out of relevancy, or transposed to what we consider math today—yet here today the arbitrary number 60, written in decimal, remains inert. Now is but the cumulative residue of legacy; the fabric of time woven with

fragments of lost meaning.

Or is anything arbitrary—60 is a fortunate number for mathematics—maybe the Babylonians discovered how to measure time *because* of their inherited numbers. Their discovery but the product of the trajectory of their past—propelling them to take the next progressive step of human understanding: could Newton, or Leibniz have developed calculus, if they were burden to do their long division with Roman numerals?

The survival of ideas have by some been associated with Darwin's Natural Selection: knowledge—that is useful to its carrier(or not so useful, predatory even, as with the spreading of a cult)—is remembered and passed on. Information that is easily shared, like an infectious joke, or a compelling fireside tale, survives the erosion of time. And just like in biology, numbers like 60, like our useless appendix, still remains inert—a relic of the past without function but for the telling of time. The phenomenon might best be exemplified with language, they slowly change, become dialects, merge and borrow words, some die and others spread to conquer the earth! But as with any stochastic process, they appear—insofar as we are capable to discern—as noise; and only when we zoom out, over the vast frames that is our history, we are able to see the undeniable signal.

Whatever our history has to teach, when Hroðulf saw a shadow and realized what it meant—finding a deeper truth. Did he consider the future crows, who would grow up burdened to learn his clock—that the arbitrary numbers of stones he chose for his sundial would be the last piece to remain from his existence on earth? Did he consider the implications of his societal economic experiments, what society it would create, and that it, once set loose, would be unstoppable and irre-

versible when reaching motion?

By the time Cinnamon finally exhausted her curiousness, the sun was about to go down. The two chipmunks began their journey back to Kraerion's hollow. They took another way back, as to see other parts of the forest than on their way there. They wandered once again in silence, but this time it was different and free from tension. It was their silence, the one they had shared for so many years; a silence to grow old in. Both felt it, yet they likewise knew that their paths would soon diverge.

"You know, it's not that far between your borrow and my hollow...", Kraerion began cautiously.

"I know.", Cinnamon said slowly.

"You think we could give it a try?"

"I don't know, maybe...", she almost whispered, but then she nodded, "sure.". They didn't exchange any other word the short distance back to the hollow, they didn't need to. Kraerion thought back to Hroðulf's line, 'our sun is eternal bound', entertained the idea, and smiled a solemn smile at his own folly.

Diversion

> "The struggle of man against power is the struggle of memory against forgetting."
>
> - Milan Kundera

It might be easy—in places of kind latitudes, or times of modern comforts—to forget the implications of seasons. The beautiful autumn fires had raged for weeks in the forest's canopy, and now the leaves were falling; a red and orange royal carpet to invite the forth and final season.

When Man first left the forest many a generation ago, the animals came together in the glade of representatives with a sole objective: to survive winter. It was an unprecedented time, never before in the history of animal had they been free and able to meet as equals. It was a frenzy of excitement, a glade drunk on future prospects, a crowd eager to hear the words a crow uttered: "No flake of snow shall fall, til every Animal seeth a path to spring". Words that once said could not be unspoken, irrevocably written into the cultural fabric of the forest—a phrase that became known as the Crow's Law. But, more importantly, it became *legend*—the essential moral in the tales that every mother told their kitten, pup, squawk,

or bunny.

No matter how beautiful the law appeared to the first animals, reality seldom bends to beauty; the law was rather burdensome to implement and straight insipid in practice. There were simply too many an animal to listen to them all; but even so, the small fraction of animals that did speak, had a tendency to refrain from the truth. It requires little difficulty to imagine why an animal would not want to stand up, in front of the whole forest—and all potential mates—and declare himself incompetent: to advertise his inability to survive winter without aid.

Nevertheless, it was *law*. So the day after the first frost, the animals gathered—as the first animals had done—in the glade for their annual pre-winter meeting.

"Craax—Hares!", Eaglewing cried tiredly, without any of his usual passion for the spoken word, as the fifth hour in the glade began, "Thou art next, Snowball."

"Okay,", the hare—who looked nothing like a snowball—said. But over the coming weeks she would—as would the forest—reveal her dormant beauty and gain a gorgeous white coat. "Our burrows are filled to the brim, we've estimated that we have collected approximately 10% more produce than yesteryear. And, like always, most of us have paid into the Winter Fund as well."

"And dost thou speak for all hares?", Eaglewing asked, as he had done—verbatim—many a time before, as that was the exact phrasing that was deemed to comply with the Crow's Law.

"Inasmuch as I'm aware.", Snowball answered, which equally was the custom hedging response every animal who spoke for

more than herself used.

"If any hare doth not feel spoken fore—speaketh now!"

"...let the record show that the hare seeth a path to spring.", Eaglewing continued in the still heavily scripted language before moving on to the next speaker. And, so it went on for hours.

The species in the forest varied greatly in their independence; whilst the hares, the rabbits, and chipmunks only required one speaker each, there was just as many on the other side of the spectrum. For instance, all magpies and roebucks represented themselves, each outbragging the next. The roebucks were particular notorious for their bragging, since their natural horn jousting had been outlawed, their need to dominate each other had found its way to this moment and their tales bordered on the ridiculous. The moles—who spoke their own peculiar language and seldom partook in the forest's functions—also lined up individually. Although, they went quickly by, each proclaiming a variation of the same sentence: "Ic hæbbe fōda nôg."

The sun was setting by the time all had been accounted for, save for the crows themselves who never spoke. Now but an update from the Winter Fund remained before the animals could head back to their burrows and nests.

"Before I leave the word to Aequitus and the Winter Fund, let me leave this final remark.", Eaglewing began, as he regained his usual tact,

> "It looketh like we have successfully prepared for another winter. And it warmeth my heart that nigh every year we gather here, we are better along than

> the year before. Incrementally our quality of life improveth. Each year's improvement might appear invisible to the naked eye; nonetheless, over generations—in aggregate, since our humble beginnings—these changes be breathtaking.
>
> Ought we not be content with our progress? Oughtest thou not stand back in awe and admire our accomplishments? No, our pace be lousy at best! We have by no means inherited a perfect system. We are at the whims of markets—it ebbs, it flows—but it be never stable; and we suffer for it: wasting value in good times; erasing value in bad times—capricious jobs created; honest jobs lost, and progress resets. And, even worse: unfairness be an innate quality of markets, its abundance be distributed—by the sick wiles of Nature—according to a power law. To wit, as the book of Man saith: whoever hath, more shall be given; whoever hath not, even that shall be taken away.
>
> No, we ought not be content. Thou oughtest not stand in awe. And the first steps have already been taken: to ease the ebbs and flows of our markets; to reserve parts of our forest solely for recreation; to aid the Animals of our poorest percentiles—to eradicate destitution. Last namely: as ye already know, we imposed a small tax on transportation this previous spring which will aid a new institution; a program which will help animals who caneth afford to participate in the Winter Fund. Never again shall an Animal find herself in destitution—the only lack: a dearth of hunger."

The crow with a brown wing looked around for a while, gauging the response from the animals. He seemed pleased, and he continued:

”Thou hast waited patiently, Aequitus. Let us conclude this gathering with thy Winter Fund—have we naught to fear these coming winter months?”

”Thank you, Eaglewing.”, Aequitus said formally as he took a few steps forward. With those steps, it became apparent to certain animals, including Kraerion, what he wasn’t—in the company of Veritas. ”Uhm, yes, we have indeed a record level of produce in our stores. And our low year-over-year churn have dropped even further. The fear of churn with the once rumored—now proclaimed—forest program, have thus, albeit early, not materialized.”

”So thou sayest—to be exlicit—we have naught to fear this winter?”

”Yes—that is indeed what I am saying.”

”I thank thee! If no one else hath something to contribute, I regard winter as welcome and this meeti—”

”HOLD IT CROW!”, Αίσωπος cried assertively from somewhere out of sight. The animals around him moved away hastily; again, less from his hideous stank, but rather to show no doubt of any association with him. ”I do believe you’re forgetting something.”

”Oh, dost thou?”, Eaglewing answered glibly, ”What have I forgotten, please enlighten us!”

”Quit the theater Eagleshit; you’ve not become senile and you—and everyone else in this damned Glade—know to what I’m referring to.”

”Oh, I do?”, the crow chuckled amused, ”Well then, couldst thou not be a lamb and remind the rest of us of what we already know?”

”So it’s theater then—I’ll give you theater, but let the record show that this was never my intent.”, the badger said, he crawled

up on a rock next to the Old Oak as to be closer in height with Eaglewing, but instead of facing the crow, he turned to Br'er Rabbit. "I hold Br'er Rabbit to be an honest and trusted member of our Forest, do the Animals in this Glade agree?"

Some of the animals nodded, others muttered something akin to a 'yes', or 'aye', and someone chimed in with a 'hear hear'. There was no doubt: Br'er Rabbit was trustworthy.

"I thought as much.", Αίσωπος said, "Br'er Rabbit, can you answer me this: the leaves we exchanged for our hard earned screw nuts, wasn't it but a temporary means to stop theft?"

"Yes, I suppose that's true.", Br'er Rabbit said puzzled, unaware of what Αίσωπος might have planned.

"And, haven't crime been absent for quite a while now—not even one recorded case of theft since spring?"

"Yes, that's indeed also true."

"Well, isn't it then in order for us to return to the screw nuts as it was decided—or Eaglewing, was this never intended to be temporary?"

"Seizeth him!", Eaglewing bellowed, and within seconds Αίσωπος was surrounded by stoats. The stoats were still merely more than kits, yet their fierce nature were without question: their weight but red in tooth and claw. "Dost thou take us for fools? The theft has stopped *because* of the transition to leaves; if we return to screw nuts, thou couldst but begin steeling again. Here, fellow Animals, the evidence be self evident—the screw nut thief be standing before ye. Why else would he careth so deeply about the reinstatement of screw nuts?"

"BECAUSE—", Αίσωπος roared whilst slowly spinning around in a circle—claws unsheathed—as to not expose his back to the same stoat for more than a moment at a time, "I DO NOT TRUST CROWS!"

Then everything happened very quickly. The stoat behind Αίσωπος leaped forward, his claws reaching for the badger's back. Αίσωπος spun around, but not fast enough, and the blow caught him in his right cheek, the claws cutting deep. Blood appeared, but the badger did not flinch; instead, he leaned his body and face into the stoat and—before the stoat had a chance to flee—caught its neck in his teeth. A loud crack filled the glade as the neck gave way and the brave youth was no more. The now injured badger saw his chance: he bolted for the opening in the circle that the dead stoat had left behind. Before the dead body had touched the ground, the other stoats were on him from all angels. He ran for his life, away and out of the glade; the stoats in full pursuit like that of a tail chasing its kite.

The dead stoat just laid there in the center of the glade. The grass soaking itself red. Dead silence entered the glade, and it screamed like never before.

"Craax.", Eaglewing croaked, but instead of speaking he calmly put his beak under his discoloured brown wing and started cleaning it. He took his time and showed no hint of haste—he appeared completely detached or undisturbed by the event that just transpired. He told his threat with silence. "Let this be a lesson ye learn as it's nonce taught. Αίσωπος be guilty, as witnessed here today. He be beyond law—an Enemy of the Forest—free to be killed by whomsoever feeleth desire. Yet screw nuts are like oxygen to Αίσωπος and those similarly inclined; he might lurk in the outskirts of the Forest for months without trace or risk of capture. Therefore I must decree that henceforth:"

All forms of private hoarding of SCREW NUTS—

including those usages as ornamentation, holding for sentimental value, or otherwise tertiary application—shall be forbidden. All Animals are hereby ORDERED TO DELIVER, on or before the FIRST SNOWFALL, to this GLADE OF REPRESENTATIVES, or to me, or to any crow directly in my service, all SCREW NUTS now owned by them, or SCREW NUTS coming into their possession. Upon delivery the SCREW NUTS shall be redeemed an by equal worth in LEAVES. Omission to comply to this Order will: if deemed unintentional, be subject to a FINE not exceeding FIVE LEAVES; however, if deemed willful, the subject shall be sentenced to a DEATH BY STOAT.

Part 2

On Dreams in the Aggregate

Discrepancy

> "Concentrated power is not rendered harmless by the good intentions of those who create it."
>
> - Milton Friedman

The winter came early and hard. The migratory birds had long fled south to the more pleasant European—and even African—continents; the winter air was thus calm and quiet, save for the irregular cooing of the pigeons. The forest bed was covered in a thick layer of snow, its distribution made uneven by the wind and the trees. The animals hid in their burrows and lairs for most of the days, huddled close to preserve body heat. Winter was but a game of waiting—a quarter of life on pause.

Kraerion wasn't immune to cold either, and he had prepared meticulously for winter: insulating the inner walls of his hollow with moss and lichen. He had Redrill carve him a round wooden disc, which could be rolled in front of his entrance to keep the shy warmth hostage. In the mornings, though, he pushed the disc aside; he preferred the cold to the darkness, and a life in motion to a life on pause. He had watched as the days shrank, the morning dew slowly morph to morning frost—a phenomenon difficult to grasp for a creature raised

underground. And today—this particular morning—the sun rays danced for Kraerion's eyes on the unadulterated hoar frost covering the surface, seemingly stretching forever in every direction. A dance of free admission, open to all, yet but a lone chipmunk hunched in a tree paid to attend—and, in that moment, he was truly the richest animal in the forest.

The sun shifted and its rays intercepted by a pine, the dance moved on to other glades. Kraerion's mind wandered to the events in the Glade: the attempted seizure of Αίσωπος, the death of the young stoat, and the Decree. The now outlawed badger had never officially been apprehended, and no one knew for sure where he was. Nevertheless, many a rumour spread like wildfire that early winter. "He had been caught, killed, and buried by the stoats!", he had heard Spinestack boast to Greyhead. "No, he is still in hiding in some old forgotten badgers' lair deep underground—biding his time!" Greyhead had conjectured back to Spinestack. "No, he sought out supporters to his cause, roaming the marshes to the east of the forest and preparing for war!", a Robin had chimed to anyone who would listen as he flew by Kraerion's birch.

No one had definitive proof of their claims, yet the animals argued incessantly about it. Kraerion didn't know what to make of it himself. He didn't know the badger personally—no one truly did—but he had always appeared to him to be an animal of reason. He couldn't wrap his head around how quickly Eaglewing had reached a verdict. Could Αίσωπος really be that cut-throat?

His morning conundrum was abruptly disturbed by Cinnamon who suddenly, hastily entered the glade, in stark con-

trast to the leisurely pace of that late summer morning. This time she didn't stop at the base of the birch; instead—to Kraerion's surprise—she sprang up it without hesitation, her claws tearing at the bark in her urgency. When she reached the hollow, she was breathless, her small chest heaving as she fought to recover. She didn't have to speak for Kraerion to realize she came with news; and looking into her pearl black eyes, he saw that the news was grave.

"Veritas is dead", she finally mustered, still panting, "I think you better come."

They ran back together through the winter silence which no longer appeared nearly as beautiful as it had just a few minutes before, only heavy. They entered the run and Cinnamon led the way through the many twists and turns that were slowly fading from Kraerion's memory. When they finally entered Veritas's spartan burrow, they were both out of breath. "There's too many chipmunks for this space...", Kraerion thought to himself as he pushed past the scurry with Cinnamon on his heels, "too many damn chipmunks." He saw his father leaning over his sister's lifeless body—his forepaw gently resting on her chest. Pietus was also standing there; he looked up when they approached and gave them a silent nod. Aequitus didn't notice them or didn't care to show if he did. Kraerion suddenly felt a cold thought creeping up his spine: "Even in death, she had defied Nature. animals seldom die in burrows; they seek a quiet, open space for their final rest. Veritas, however, chosen this confined space—sealing herself in with the very truth she preached." Overwhelmed with emotions, Kraerion finally had enough. "Get out of here!", he screamed suddenly, the ferocity of his own voice surpised him, "Get out of here, all of you!"

When no one moved a limb, Aequitus finally looked up from Veritas's body. "You heard him", the Cheif bellowed, his voice ragged but commanding, "Get out!"

And so the chipmunks did—revealing that Kraerion's voice no longer carried the same weight as it once did. As the burrow emptied, Cinnamon turned to follow, but Kraerion quickly placed a paw on her shoulder. "Not you", he whispered, "stay with me."

When only Aequitus, Pietus, Cinnamon, and Kraerion remained in the burrow, they remained in silence. It was a heavy silence, as if by not speaking they could somehow deny the reality of the situation.

"What...", Kraerion asked at length, his voice trembling, "what happened?

"I..., she. I don't", Aequitus stammered, "I... I think she starved herself."

"What do you mean?", Kraerion asked confused, "She couldn't—why would she starve?"

Aequitus looked like he was about to speak, but the words died in his throat, a single tear rolling down his cheek before he turned away.

Pietus sighed heavily, "It's hard to say for certain what was going through her mind. She was... agitated. She was angry with the Crows, but mostly with me and your father. She had this notion that the Winter Fund was underfunded— that we needed to sound the alarm immediately. The rest of us disagreed." Pietus paused, glancing at Aequitus for input; when none came, he continued, "She threatened to disclose her concerns to the forest. We... we found it necessary to confine her to her burrow on the day of the assembly in the Glade. After that, she became withdrawn. She began rationing her feed—a

silent protest to show what we all ought to be doing. We never imagined she would take it this far."

"Why did no one think to tell me?", Kraerion asked, now angry, "We could have saved her!"

"I *did* tell you Kraerion", Cinnamon interjected gently, trying with all her might to keep compassion in her voice, "Do you think it was easy for me to seek you out after you left like you did? I told you she was struggling... but you chose not to hear."

"Feed is dialectic; hunger is constant. The delta must eventually reverse." Kraerion whispered, recalling that summer morning. The anger in him deflated instantly, replaced by a heavy pain of guilt in his chest. "But, I still don't get it", Kraerion begain again, "What would make her think the Winter fund was underfunded?"

"Well, it's a bit complicated", Pietus answered, rubbing his temples, "But, I'll try to do justice to Veritas's argument. When the swap from screw-nuts to leaves happend, there was a liquidity crisis of sort. For example, we paid the moles this year to widen the eastern tunnel, but since we had to convert our screw-nuts to leaves first, we had to postpone the project a week or so."

Pietus gestured vaguely with a paw. "Similar projects got delayed all over the forest, causing economic activity to slow down. When demand falls, so does prices; and when prices fall, animals tend to hold back on spending in expectation that prices will drop even further. It's a vicious cycle Veritas explained."

"Sounds very reasonable to me,", Cinnamon said, "Why would you stop her from telling the Forest?"

"Because she was a fool!", Aequitus suddenly exploded,

his voice echoing through the burrow. "She might have been the brightest chipmunk, near erie grasp of our economic system, but when it came to Animals, she was a fool!" He paced the small burrow, his shadow flickering on the earthen walls. "She thought we could just *tell* them! That Animals are just this all-loving cooperative bunch of beings, surely no one could be so impolite as to get upset when they learn their kin might starve to death? No... It would have caused pandemonium! Chaos! Fighting in the glades! It's unfortunate, but if you strip away this thin veil of civility, we are but nasty, brutish beasts in the state of nature!"

"I'm sorry...", Aequitus sighed, his anger spent, "It's unfair to her. She was right about the Winter Fund, just not the way to fix it. She's gone now... gone forever.".

"It's not that we didn't listen to her.", Pietus added, "On the contrary, we heeded her warnings. We sought help from the crows, and they took the warnings seriously. They provided us with more leaves on the spot, and arranged for a line of credit to be set up in case we needed more funding. The problem has been to find more feed to buy, here again the crows have been helping us, brokering a deal with the beavers that had some extra feed stored this winter. Br'r Rabbit has also been helping us, his scouts have been going nest to nest looking for surplus feed to buy."

Pietus paused to take a deep breath, "So you see Kraerion, we have done everything in our power to heed Veritas's warnings; it may be a winter of dearth, but we've given the Winter Fund good odds of making it through."

Silence claimed the burrow once more. There was nothing left to discuss; economics could not reverse death, nor could self-pity fill a belly that had ceased to hunger.

"We must bury her...", Kraerion said at length. He felt a heavy ache in his chest; usually, the dying slipped away into the night to pass alone, not here among the living. "Before her body starts to..." He didn't finish the sentence; he didn't have to.

They wrapped Veritas in her bedding, a humble shroud of woven grass and dried moss. It took all four of them to maneuver her lifeless body through the narrow twists of the runs. The walls felt suffocatingly tight as they dragged the bundle upwards. Reaching an intersection of runs, they met a couple of chipmunks coming the other way. "Hazelpaw," Pietus greeted one of them, "could you fetch one of the moles and a blackbird, and have them meet us at the grey willow?" The chipmunk nodded and hurried away. When the group emerged into the white glare of winter, the sun was beginning to dip, casting long, mournful shadows across the snow.

The scurry made their way to the grey willow; Aequitus dug away the layer of snow only to find the turf beneath frozen solid.

"I'm glad we ran into Hazelpaw", Pietus muttered, "We'll need the moles to dig the grave."

The wait for the mole was agonizing. The cold gnawed at their fur; Cinnamon huddled close to Kraerion, shivering against the biting wind. It wasn't long, however, before the snow shifted nearby. A mound of earth erupted from the white blanket—shattering the pristine surface. A black snout appeared, followed by massive spade-like paws.

"Hwæt?", the mole grumbled, "Hwȳ wēccest þū mec of mīnum slǣpe?"

"We're sorry to wake you from your sleep, Burrowfoot", Aequitus began, "But we need a grave, and our claws don't

cut it in this frozen ground. Of course we'll compensate you well for the short notice."

"Nā", Burrowfoot grunted, "þis is hūsgifu."

And the mole set to work immediately, his powerful paws throwing up clumps of frozen earth with ease. The blackbird arrived shortly after; perched silently on a nearby branch, he observed the proceedings with solemn eyes.

When the hole was deep enough, the chipmunks gently lowered Veritas's body into the grave. The blackbird needed no instructions; he began to sing a mournful melody that echoed through the cold winter air.

Cheeks are empty, cold and still, Sleep beneath the quiet hill. Digging done and running past, You are home and safe at last.

Leave the burden, leave the load, Travel down the final road. To the Harvest, rich and deep, While the living wake and weep.

Join the roots, become the seed, Free from hunger, free from need. Cheeks are empty, cold and still, Sleep beneath the quiet hill.

Dilution

"The long run is a misleading guide to current affairs.
In the long run we are all dead."

- John Maynard Keynes

Deep winter had sealed the world, locking the promise of spring in a distant, unreachable future. The frost was not merely on the ground and in the trees; it was in the marrow. And while the turning of the earth guaranteed that spring must eventually conquer winter, to a starving animal, the 'eventual' is a rather poor substitute for the 'now'.

Yet, against the odds, the animals had endured—even done great given the circumstance. The tragedy of Veritas's death had served as a grim wake-up call. The chipmunks had heavily rationed their food stores, and that of the Winter Fund. Through influential animals loyal to them—like rabbits, and the hares—the message of low feed stores had been spread throughout the forest. It had been done subtly, very carefully, so as not to incite panic, and been effective enough to stop any real catastrophe in its tracks.

In the end, the animals were going to survive the winter, but it would still be the worst winter in living memory. And,

as with any setback, there's plenty of blame to go around—whether the blame is justified is seldom of concern when seeking scapegoats.

"Eveything set?", Br'r Rabbit whispered to his right-paw rabbit Thlayli as the first light of dawn broke through into the glade. The two rabbits were hutched within a thick bush—invisible to any animal in the glade.

"Yes, Br'r", Thlayli replied softly, "the beavers, the moles, the rats, the hares, the mice, the squirrels, the hedgehogs, and songbirds of various feathers, all have some form of representation in the area. Your message will not go unnoticed."

"How about the chipmunks, and the deer?", Br'r rabbit asked, as he licked his paw and anxiously dragged it over his long ears. "Is Aequitus here?"

"No, Br'r.", Thlayli replied hesitantly, "He's..—He's been hard to reach these days. But Pietus will be here. And, the two biggest deer-bucks have promised you their protection if fighting breaks out. I can't get a visual though, they are too big to hide here. They should be within earshot."

"Good enough.", Br'r Rabbit sighed, "and the stoats?"

"Far away, Br'r.", Thlayli assured and a big grin spread across his face, "They swallowed the bait of the Aesop sighting in the east meadows. Every stoat is off searching for him save for Eaglewings personal stoat. It was genius of you to spread the rumors through the moles—the crows are too arrogant to think blind animals in a strange tongue could contain any cunning."

"I still got one last trick in me.", Br'r Rabbit chuckled amused. "Now let's get to work.".

Br'r Rabbit had always been full of tricks, using his cunning and wit to get his way. But he was not young anymore, and his brain growing slower for each day. He had been angry, very angry—both with himself and with the crows—for the introducing the stoats into the forest, and his own failure to act against it. His last trick, would be to release the bottled tension of the winter's suffering directly at the crows—tension that would erupt on Br'r rabbits terms.

Snow was still covering the ground, when Br'r Rabbit made his way to the edge of the Glade—the very spot where he had failed to act against the introduction of the stoats.

"This is not money!", he loudly proclaimed, his voice raw. "This is a lie!"

He dug a small hole in the snow in front of the Old Oak, and into that hole, he deposited a large pile of leaves.

"We trusted your scheme, Eaglewing!", he cried, as animals gathered from all sides around him as planned, and a few sleepy crows came out of the Old Oak to see what the commotion was about. "We followed everything you asked of the forest, yet we had to ration and starve just to get through the winter—is that what *progress* is to you?"

Before he let any crow respond, he turned around, and with his short round white tail high in the air, he defecated on the pile of leaves.

"To all the animals present in this Glade:", Br'r Rabbit continued, "Let it be known that henceforth, the rabbits will no longer accept leaves as a form payment for our goods or services. We will accept blueberries—and only blueberries—until the crows sees it fit to return our screw-nuts!"

Eaglewing appeared from a hollow in the Old Oak, his

black feathers ruffled by the cold air. The crow glared down at Br'r Rabbit.

"What treachery be th...", he began, his voice sharp, but he was immediately interrupted by the thunder of a great buck stepping forward.

"**No leaves, no leaves, no leaves!**", the buck bellowed, and the chant was quickly taken up by the rest of the animals, until the entire glade was roaring in unison.

Eaglewing stiffened. He opened his beak to retort, to weave a spell of words as he had done so often, but his voice was drowned in the feverish chant. He saw the anger in their eyes—a hunger that mere rhetoric could not feed. A rebuke at this moment would only ignite their frenzy.

With a sharp snap of his wings, the crow turned his back on the mob, feigning indifference, and retreated into the Old Oak.

Br'r Rabbit did not stay to watch the fire he had lit. He slipped into the dense undergrowth where Thlayli was waiting.

"Our work here is done.", he whispered, a youthful mischievous glint in his old eyes, "Let's get out of here before it turns ugly."

As soon as Eaglewing was out of sight from the Glade, he abandoned all pretense of composure. He let his fury be known with a violent thrash of his wings, knocking over a heap of nuts that scattered across the hollow floor.

"Dispatch a magpie for the stoats!", he commanded the nearest crow, his eyes narrowing. "And summon Hroðulf hither immediately. The Rabbit fancies himself cunning; let us see how his parlor tricks fare against the full weight of Law."

The following days the temperature rose sharply. The thaw came with a vengeance, the meltwater saluting the coming of spring by transforming the trails into muddy brooklets . Initially, the animals had rejoiced, believing Br'r Rabbit's plan had liberated them. But a terrible realization soon dawned on the Forest: blueberries were a poor substitute for a currency. Blueberries were seasonal, ripening only in the heat of late summer. Worse, they all had their wealth tied up in the leaves that effectively became worthless overnight—reducing everyone's savings to zero. The playing field had, for the moment, been reset.

"How could I be so foolish?", Br'r Rabbit muttered, seeing a rat and beaver struggling to barter as neither had any blueberries to their name. He hopped through a muddy trail, his ears drooped low. "Why did I pick blueberries...? My plan was flawed from the start—I'm truly too old for this."

As the rabbit came into a clearing, he was intercepted by a large magpie.

"Br'r Rabbit.", the magpie squawked, "I come bearing a message from Eaglewing."

Br'r rabbit's ears perked up, "Let hear it.", he said shortly.

"Eaglewing demands a meeting with you, Snowball, and Pietus, at a time and place of your choosing. The crow wishes to discuss a possible amicable resolution to this... predicament. He has promised to not bring any stoats to the meeting. And I quote: '..Let him bring those testy bucks of his, or any other animals he fancies for protection.' Would you like me to return a message?"

The rabbit didn't answer at once; instead, he sat down for a moment, mulling over the offer. Finally, he simply nodded an agreement. "Tell him I'll meet him three days from now,

when the sun is at its peak, at the grove next to Rabbit Hill."

The magpie took flight, setting off to search for Snowball and Pietus, before returning to the crows.

Three days later, just as the sun passed its zenith, Eaglewing and Hroðulf made their way into the grove. Br'r Rabbit, Snowball, and Pietus were already waiting. Behind them, the two bucks stood in the shadows, swaying their heavy antlers back and forth in a silent threat.

"Ah what a delightful mess thou hast made, Br'r Rabbit", Eaglewing began, his tone dripping of false sympathy.

"Blue—berr—ies", Hroðulf added, struggling to quench his laughter. "Out of everything you could have picked... you picked *blueberries*."

"You're right.", Br'r Rabbit admitted calmly, "Blueberries were perhaps a poor choice. But you're attacking a straw-animal. You know full well that was a desperate measure; our real intention is—and always has been—to return to the screw-nunts."

"We're sorry...", Eaglewing said, exchanging a glance with Hroðulf, who was still fighting a smirk, "We know you're just trying to act in the best interest of the forest. It's just that... well, you don't seem to afford us the same courtesy. Spreading your misdirected gospel in the Public... thou could simply have come to us."

"Not even!", Hroðulf interjected, "You may think whatever you want about the efficacy of our actions. Eaglewing saw an issue, and he acted in good faith to solve it, going through all the proper slow bureaucratic channels. And yet, you plan a coup in secret—undermining our Representative Glade, and stoop so low as to defecate on our way of governance. Shame!

"That's a convenient way to retell the events.", Br'r Rabbit retorted, "But let's stick to the facts. *You* introduced the leaves. The economy slowed as a direct consequence of the shift, and now *we* have to deal with the fallout. Forget the blueberries—let us just go back to the screw-nuts and be done with it."

"Fair enough,", Hroðulf said, composing himself, "Let's stick to the matter of hand. However, your premise is flawed. The economy didn't slow becase of the leaves; it slowed because the animals were too afraid to trade with a theif loose in the forest."

He waved a wing dismissively before anyone could interrupt, "It's a moot point now, isn't it? The economy *has* slowed. It needs a fresh start. So tell me: how does going back to screw-nuts fix that?"

"Because...", Br'r Rabbit hesitated, searching for the right words, "Well, the screw-nuts are *real*. They've stood the test of time—they simply work. The leaves were an untested experiment, and it failed. We need to go back to what we know."

"Interesting.", Hroðulf mused, "That did not answer my question, though. Let me rephrase it through a metaphor: Is water water?"

"What is this non-sense?", Snowball interrupted.

"What are you playing at Crow!?", Pietus muttererd frustrated, "is this what you call an explanation?"

"Well, yes!", Hroðulf exclaimed, "Metaphors are these precious little things—tender and digestible with reality abstracted, to afford even the dullest of minds—like yours—some amount of comprehension. So please, indulge me: is water water?"

"Fine... Yes Hroðulf.", Br'r Rabbit said at length, "If you must. Water is water."

"Thank you, Br'r Rabbit.", Hroðulf said, his tone softening. "Now, ask the salmon, who dares his life on his heroic journey upstream—does he swim to live in water instead of water?

Ask the beaver, who spends his days damning the brook to create a pond—does he labour to live in water instead of water?

Ask the doe, whose fawn drank from a stale puddle born with disease instead of the running brook as she was taught... Ask her if water is just water?"

The crow paused, letting the question hang in the air, before answering his own question. "No, water is not water if life is not death. Water is only a canvas, a medium that can be altered, shaped, and most importantly: controlled."

Hroðulf took another longer pause, looked each of them in the eye before continuing.

"And right now our economy is like that stale puddle. There's no activity in it, there's no life. How would we solve that problem, how would we make the water move?"

The grove was quiet for a long time, until finally Br'r Rabbit spoke.

"Rain.", he said slowly, "You want to flood the market with leaves?"

"Exactly, Br'r Rabbit.", Hroðulf said, "flood is a perfect word. You see, Economics are not bound by fixed axiomatic truths like physics. It's entirely the product of our creation; it's made by us, for us. If we crave for two plus two to equal five, then we could simply change the axioms to make it so. Or

two plus two can be whatsoever the Crax we want it to be! To let it rain for forty days and forty nights, our stale puddle of an economy, flushed clean, into a wide maelstrom of activity."

"Do you see yourself a God?", Snowball uttered, "cause

"I think you're forgetting your place here Crow", Br'r Rabbit said sternly, "You are but a servant of the forest, not its master. We're not in the Glade of Representatives, and you will never find quorum on this. We have no obligation to follow your insanity."

"The chipmunks will stand with the majority", Pietus added.

"Great!", Eaglewing exclaimed, "That's all we ask. Then let's settle it with a forest wide vote—let's see what the animals think of this proposal and decide in let's say... four weeks?"

"Wait", Br'r Rabbit said as he was thinking it over, "four weeks are too long—let's half it to two weeks. Either we agree to bring back the screw-nuts, or we start to use the leaves again."

"Agreed.", Eaglewing nodded, "We'll meet in two weeks time in the Glade of Representatives and each vote-bearing animal may cast their vote."

Duty

> "Until they become conscious they will never rebel, and until after they have rebelled they cannot become conscious."
>
> - George Orwell

The sun rose slowly above the tree line, the first rays piercing the entrance of Kraerion's hollow in the birch. As had now become habit, the chipmunk sat perched at the threshold, watching the world wake up. But unlike the weeks prior, where a calm and beautiful winter lanscape had greeted him, only a grey slop of dead undergrowth and leafless trees met Kraerion's gaze. The thaw left the forest naked, in limbo, before the spring would arrive and dress it.

And unlike the previous weeks, he no longer felt the same gratitude for the sun's warmth. He no longer feel like the richest animal in the forest.

"Is this it?", he thought somberly, "Is this the life I've been chasing all my life?"

He had been so focused on the pursuit—on the thrill of achieving it—that he never considered, never anticipated, the feelings that had now caught up to him. Guilt. A heavy weight

in his chest. It was the feelings of loss, and the gnawing knowledge of his inability to prevent it. He knew, rationally, that he wasn't responsible for Veritas's death. Yet, a whisper in his mind insisted that if he had made different choices—less unorthodox choices, less selfish choices—Veritas would still be alive and well.

He shook his head, pushing the thoughts aside. That line of thinking would never lead to anything good.

Kraerion sighed, and stood up. He began to climb down from the birch. Every day since Veritas's death, he had gone back to his family's burrows underground, and today was no exception. He landed on the ground, his feet sinking into the mud as he walked towards the run. The path usually offered him solitude, but not today; the forest was bustling with animals, all of them in frantic hurry.

As he rounded a bend on path, he had to step off it entirely. A team of beavers were heading in the opposite direction, but instead of carrying logs for a dam, they were hauling large bulging pouches.

"Make way! Make way!", the first beaver shouted, his voice surprisingly cheerful for the early morning.

Kraerion had no choice but to step aside, he leaped onto a tree stump to let them pass.

"Oh sorry there, Kraerion!", the beaver said. Kraerion recognized him as Castor, a friendly but a *simple* creature. "I didn't see you there!"

"That looks like a heavy load—", Kraerion said, pointing a paw at the pouch. "Building a new dam?"

"No, no, no! It's not for the dam", Castor replied, a wide grin appearing on his face. "It's a thick bundle of leaves from

the Crows. They're commissioning a massive windmill on the other side of the river. Bought the land from the hedgehogs!"

"A windmill?", Kraerion said, puzzled. "What is a windmill?"

"I don't know exactly.", Castor answered honestly, "but I think it's some kind of machine to make bread..."

"But what is bread?", Kraerion asked, even more confused, "Is it some kind of food?"

"Yes! you know those city birds that live in the wadborough village", a younger beaver Kraerion didn't recognize chimed in, "Um, the winged rats of the sky I think they're called. They eat it all the time!"

"Winged rats?", Kraerion snapped, "They're called pigeons. You're aware that Chipmunks are also rodents, aren't you?"

"Ah, relax, Kraerion", Castor said quickly. "He means no offense—beavers are rodents too, after all! Yes, pigeons eat it—they call it *Breadcrumb aux Poubelles*, it's a delicacy, the best food of them all, apparently!"

"I see", Kraerion said after a while, still wrapping his head around the absurdity of it. "And, they've already paid you?"

"Paid us upfront, yes!", Castor laughed slapping the pouch on his back, "For the whole summer's labour! It's all part of a bigger incentive to increase demand, or something like that. RAIN they called it, I don't remember what it stands for, though."

"It means", the younger beaver added, "Rebuild Abundance, Invest in Nature." The young beaver beamed proudly, looking at castor for approval, who nodded slightly in his direction.

"Thanks Flat-tail", Castor remarked as he opened his pouch, "But never mind some silly name—LOOK AT THIS, Kraerion.

I've never seen this much wealth in my life. The missus is already planning to expand our lodge in the dam, it's all very exciting!"

"That's great Castor...", Kraerion said at length, he could sense that there was something terribly wrong with the whole situation—but what exactly, he couldn't put his paw on it. Then it dawned on him. "But what about the screw-nuts? What about the vote next week?"

The beaver's grin faltered, but only for a second. He leaned in, lowering his voice conspiratorially, "Well, that's the thing. It's in the deal, Clause four to be exact. If the vote goes in favor of the screw-nuts, the contract is voided. They said their initiative wouldn't work without the leaves. Something about liquidity and public spending, but it all sounds like greek to me."

Kraerion went still, "Voided? Don't you find that strange, Castor?"

"Well, between you and me", Castor gave Kraerion a not-so-subtle wink, "we're not the only one who's been paid, and the hedgehogs land purchase has a similar clause too. It's pretty clear how the forest will vote next week."

When Kraerion just stood there dumbfounded, Castor adjusted his pouch, "Well, time for us to get to work! We have lots of leaves to spend! See you around Kraerion!"

Kraerion watched them go, a cold dread settling in his stomach. He wondedered about the integrity of the vote, the future of the forest, but then firmly shook his head. He reminded himself that this was not his fight—this wasn't in his cards. He had his own life to build.

He hurried the rest of the way underground, slipping into

the main burrow known as the Aorta. The Aorta had always been—in Kraerion's fading memory—a place of controlled efficient chaos. But today, it was in a state of utter disarray. Messengers dashing back and forth, stacks of to-be-delivered cargo lined the earthen walls, and chipmunks stood around with a paralyzing mix of urgency and confusion. Kraerion pushed through the commotion, making his way to a side burrow that was Aequitius's personal office. Inside, he found Aequitius, who was sitting on a neat pile of straw, shaped into what best can be described as a makeshift chair. His eyes were bloodshot, his fur was unkempt—he looked like he hadn't slept in a week.

"It doesn't balance.", Aequitius muttered, scratching with a piece of dried root at the massive schematic carved into the dirt walls, clearly not noticing Kraerion's presence. "What am I missing?"

"Father?", Kraerion said, stepping into the room, "Is everything alright?"

The older chipmunk jumped, startled. "Oh, it's just you Kraerion, I didn't see you there..." Aequitius said, his voice trailing off, sounding incredibly fragile. "Sorry, I'm just... I'm trying to get my bearings again. Veritas took over the scheduling a long time ago. You see this? Is any of this making sense to you?"

"I would love to help, father", Kraerion began hesitantly, "But, to be honest, do you really think that's a good idea? You know, that's not the path I've chosen for myself"

"Not this scat again, Kraerion", Aequitius roared, his voice rising into his former self, "Don't you get it, Veritas is dead—Wake up!"

Kraerion stiffened, trying to keep his cool "I am awake,

father. There are hundreds of capable chipmunks in your service. Pick someone else, train them."

"How can you *still* not understand? I can't just pick one!" Aequitius snapped, hurling the root at the wall, "Our entire operation functions on fairness, Kraerion! Every worker earns equal pay by the amount they carry, by digging and sweating in the runs. If I arbitrarily pull a random chipmunk off the line and crown him my successor just to spare your feelings, I destroy the very meritocracy we've built!

Aequitius slumped back into his straw chair, losing his short burst of energy, suddenly looking his age again."You want to live out there like a commoner, free of the family's obligation. You were raised with privilege—with the education and the experience required to lead. Would it be fair to drop the entire weight of our enterprise onto some random chipmunk—someone without the knowledge, without the privilege to justify the burden—just because my own son is too proud to do his duty?"

He looked up at Kraerion, pleading but firm.

"Leadership isn't a prize, Kraerion; it's a burden. You didn't choose your privilege, so you can't choose your burden—that is the paradox of equality."

Kraerion stood frozen for a moment. The silence was thick and deafening, broken only by Aequitius's ragged breathing. There was a voice in Kraerion's mind screaming at him to turn around, arguing that this was not his burden to bear, that he had his own life to live. Yet, he stood there, staring at his old frail exhausted father.

Without anything better to occupy his mind, his gaze slowly drifted to the schematic on the dirt wall. At first, it just appeared as a complex, chaotic mess of lines and numbers, but

as he stared at it longer, patterns began to emerge. He saw that a scurry of chipmunks were to pick up a bundle of old hay at Rabbit's Hill at one small stone past the third big stone this very afternoon. But, just a small stone later, they were supposed to deliver twigs to a crew of woodpeckers.

There's no way they would have time to do both, he thought. He glanced back at the schematic tracing a different line. *There*—another scurry had a pickup at the robins next door at exactly four stone; they could simply handle the delivery instead.

Kraerion slowly walked towards the piece of dried root lying on the floor. He picked it up and pointed it at the wall.

"Wouldn't it be better", he began softly, "if scurry F, instead of scurry B, delivered the twigs to the woodpeckers, since they already have a pickup at the robins next door at four stones?"

Aequitius stared at the carving, then at Kraerion. Pausing for a moment, before a tired smile appeared on his weathered face. He let out long breath. "Yes", Aequitius whispered hoarsely."I don't know why I didn't see that myself."

They spent the next hour going through the schematic together, finding small inefficiencies here and there. To Kraerion's surprise, he found himself enjoying the process; it was like solving a puzzle with all the chaotic pieces snapping neatly into place.

"Have you heard about the windmill the Crows are commissioning?", Kraerion asked, suddenly remembering his unsettling conversation with Castor earlier on the trail. "What do you make of it?"

"Oh yes, the RAIN initiative, right?", Aequitius chuckled softly, "The crows never rests, do they? I don't know anything about a windmill—but we've been in talks to receive

funding from them for the Winter Fund instead of the usual premiums. It will alleviate the animals' budgets somewhat, and induce demand elsewhere."

Kraerion stopped carving, the satisfaction of problem solving vanished as quickly as it had come.

"You cooperate with them?", he asked, his voice cracking, "Even after what they did to Veritas?"

A very pained expression crossed on Aequitius's face; he looked down at the dirt floor, "There's much that went wrong this winter, and ultimately, the blame should fall on me. And, I will regret my actions for the rest of my life. But, it wasn't the damn Crows' fault—you know that, right?"

Kraerion didn't have a reply, but he knew in his bones that there was something fundamentally wrong with the whole situation. The leaves, the vote, the windmill, the subsidized Winter Fund—everything was happening too quickly. His brain physically ached just trying to keep up with his thoughts.

As he stared at his father, a horrifying realization settled over him. If he took Aequitius's place, he would be alone in this. He would have to deal with the crows.He would have to navigate the *politics*. Maybe he could handle the logistics, but *this*?. No, this was not a life. This was too much. He whispered a breathless "sorry", turned, and ran out of the office.

Kraerion pushed blindly past a group of startled chipmunks in the Aorta, his breathing shallow and erratic. He had no idea where he was going, it didn't matter; he just needed to get away. He turned a sharp corner in a run and collided hard with a soft, warm body, nearly sending them both sprawling to the ground.

"Watch your ste—", Kraerion gasped, but the words caught

in his throat.

Cinnamon steadied herself with a paw against the earthen wall. "I was actually looking for you. I have some news.", Cinnamon said offering a warm smile. But as her eyes met his, the smile vanished instantly. "Are you alright?"

"I don't know...", Kraerion managed to get out, leaning back against the wall. "I truly don't know."

Cinnamon's eyes softened, and she gave him a small, reassuring smile, "It's going to be alright, Kraerion. Let's get out of here."

They walked together in familiar, comforting silence until they reached the exit of the runs. The sun was high in the sky now, the air crisp, the day beautiful. They wandered along the trail, letting the fresh air clense their lungs.

"I don't get it", Kraerion said at length after his heart slowed and the panic subsided. "Look how beautiful the world out here is. Even now, in the grey early spring before the trees find their clothing, it's still so beautiful. How can anyone be content staying underground?"

"Don't you feel exposed out here?", Cinnamon asked curiously, her ears swiveling at the distant rustle of the wind. "I can't relax out here, I feel like I'm being watched. I feel vulnerable. Underground, I feel safe—down there, I can breathe. I'm not going to echo your father, nor lecture you about duty, but that's how I feel."

"Thanks... I see what you mean though,", Kraerion sighed, "I guess it's only natural—we used to be hunted out here."

As they wandered along, they came up to one of Hroðulf's newly built stone sun dial.

"Look at this *thing*", Kraerion said, pointing a paw to the sundial, "It's not just about spending life underground. It's

about having your life pre-determined by these stones; about having to play games with crows so as to not being taken advantage of."

He stopped himself for a moment, realizing that Cinnamon had heard him talk all about this at length, probably one time too many. His self-consciousness kicked in and he added, "I'm sorry, you've heard this before. Never mind. You said you had news, what is it?"

"Oh, right", Cinnamon answered, suddenly looking very nervous. She looked down at her paws, then finding his eyes. "This might not be the best time, but... ah shoot. I'm with kittens, Kraerion. You're going to be a father."

Duplicity

> "What you do speaks so loudly that I cannot hear what you say."
>
> - Ralph Waldo Emerson

The Old Oak stood eerily grey in the otherwise lush Glade of Representative. Its stiff leafless branches swayed naked in warm late spring breeze. The massive trunk, now hollowed out and riddled with newly excavated apartments, had sustained too much damage to pump nutrients to the canopy. Rot had began to toke hold, and larvae of all kinds feasted blindly on its dying roots.

But to Eaglewing, perched high on a barren branch, rot was simply the price of progress. He looked down upon the Glade with a profound swelling pride. *"We've done it!"*, he thought to himself. The vote had passed just over a month ago, and his many plans to better the Forest was in full motion. He peeked up to the sky, *"Look father, look have far we've come."*

Below him, the quite glade was broken by the heavy, rhythmic panting of three sturdy roebucks. They were dragging a massive, rectangular slab of limestone across the grass.

"Where do you want this?" the largest roebuck grunted, catching his breath as the trio stopped to rest.

"At the opposite end of the Glade," Eaglewing answered, his voice commanding, channeling authority. "And raise it on its short side, so it stands tall."

"And, how do you expect us to do that? the roebuck responded irritably. Eaglewing gave him a stern look, and the roebuck quickly added, "Nevermind, we'll figure it out." The bucks lower their heads, and continued to haul the stone.

Eaglewing watched them go with an amused, sly grin. *"Try to forget me now"*, he thought as his mind drifted to his childhood, and everything he had endured.

Eaglewing had not always been known as Eaglewing. He had been born Óttarr, named after his father's great-grandfather. Even as a hatchling, his left wing—a dull, patchy colour of brown—stuck out like a sore thumb. A group of older, cruel fledglings had swiftly dubbed him "Mudwing".

The nickname stuck, as ill-intentioned names tend to do. By his third winter, Óttarr had had enough. He went to his father, Ongenþeow, then the Twig, and wept over the cruelty of his peers.

His father had not comforted him. Instead, he offered cold, hard truth.

"Nicknames, especially those dispensed with malice, are like quicksand—the more you squirm, the deeper they sink." Ongenþeow had said, without even looking at his son. "The solution, I reckon, is no different than to any other problem. It is solely an affair of shaping public oppinion. You must never directly oppose your peers; float along like a log in the river and wait for an opportunity. And, when opportunity

arise, steer it in the direction of your chosing. When you learn how to control rivers, there is no lanscape you cannot mold, and no opposition you cannot erode."

Eager to gain his father's approval and to change his name, the young crow began to hatch a plan.

The first week he simply stopped taking offense when called Mudwing. The second week, he pretended to enjoy it. By the third week, he was loudly preaching to anyone who would listen about the magnificent maroon hues of mud, acting deliberately pretentious and high on himself. He was setting bait, giving the bullies a reason to knock him down a notch. He was moving the needle at a speed below perception.

He enlisted the help of his only friend, Brightbeak, keeping him in the dark about the true nature of the scheme. When the day finally came, Ottarr and Brightbeak were walking along the very fledglings who had tormented him.

"Eagles are the rats of heaven," Ottarr declared, unprovoked.

"No, they are not," snapped the largest of the bullies. "They are majestic. I've even seen one myself."

"I doubt that," Ottarr scoffed. "I you had, you would know how incredibly ugly they are, with their dull, brown wings."

"But Mudwing," Brightbeak chimed in innocently, right on cue. "Your wing is brown."

"No, my wing is a brilliant maroon!" Ottarr cried, feigning deep offense.

"No it isn't. It's the exact same color as the eagle I saw," the bully sneered slyly, falling for the bait. "You have an eagle's wing."

"How dare you compare me with one of those flying rats!" Ottarr shrieked, acting devastated.

"I think we know what this calls for," another bully laughted. The large fledgling caught on, grinning maliciously. "Surely we do. Don't we, *Eaglewing*?"

Ottar let out a wail of despair. He tucked his head under his wing and fled. Behind him, the bullies roared with laughter. They had found—or so they thought—his new weakness.

For weeks, they relentlessly called him Eaglewing. The yelled it across the glades to ridicule him; they whispered it when he walked past. Ottarr acted hurt every time, scurrying away in shame.

But though the bullies were spreading the name with malice, the rest of the murder didn't understand the nature of the joke. When they heard *Eaglewing*, they heard strength. When the younger females heard it, they heard valor. The name began to circulate through the branches outside of the group of bullies, completely stripped of its cruel context.

By the time the bullies realized that their name had backfired—it was too late. The public had adopted the name, and not even the bullies could change it now. When the bullies later went to confront Ottarr about his deceit, Ottarr simply thank them for their service, and flew away.

Ottarr won, and he would never have to be Mudwing ever again.

(Scene 3 - Eaglewing sending for a woodpecker

Denial

"Virtue is more to be feared than vice, because its excesses are not subject to the regulation of conscience."

- Adam Smith

A banging, unpleasant sound rang throughout the runs and burrows underground, signaling a new work day for the chipmunks. Kraerion woke up in his bed, rolling over to look at Cinnamon, who was still asleep. He studied his three kits, wrapped in a furry heap at the foot of the bed, feeling a contentment rivaling anything he ever known before. "How they can sleep through this noice is beyond me,", he muttered, rising up and getting himself ready for the day. "This is not so bad, though", he reminded himself—not for the first time—as he gave Cinnamon a gentle peck on the forehead before leaving their burrow.

Kraerion wasn't obligated to attend to the morning meetings in the Aorta, having already planned the day's schedule the previous evening. Shortly after he had returned to live underground, he had made a deal with Aequitius. Kraerion would only manage the internal logistics of the daily opera-

tions, whilst Pietus would be the external face—dealing with chipmunk workforce and handling the negotiations and politics with the rest of the forest. It was a compromise he could live with.

Today, however, he had a different agenda. The economic reality of the year dictated that a simple chipmunk wage would not guarantee a comfortable winter. So, he and Cinnamon had agreed that he had to sell his old hollow in the silver birch. Having found a buyer, he now only needed to close the deal.

Taking the path up to the surface jogged his memory of a different time. He exited the runs, stepping out into a a forest that felt vastly different from teh one he had left behind in the spring.

The beautiful long days of summer had passed without Kraerion having a single moment to reflect on them. Now, the trees surprised him with the flaming, bright colours of autumn. The dead, red and orange leaves covered the ground, like a red carpet, welcomed him back to the surface world.

"Where did the summer go?", he wondered solemnly, pushing forth onto the trail that would take him to his hollow. Another thought crept up on him: it was already autumn. winter was not far away, and there was still so much work that needed to happen. He pushed the thoughts aside; *one thing at the time*, he reminded himself.

The silver birch stood proud and tall, its yellow-orange leaves barely moving in the cool autumn breeze. Looking up at his former home, Kraerion felt a pang of sorrow for the life he was leaving behind. His former sanctuary, the proof of his independence and hard work—now, but an asset to be liquidated.

Waiting at the base, sat a squirrel; next to him was a stack of bundled leaves.

"Morning, Cash'ew,", Kraerion greeted, bracing himself for the pending negotiation.

"Good morning, Kraerion!", Cash'ew replied frantically, his tail twitching with manic energy. "Here are the 60 leaves we've agreed on; feel free to count them!"

"That might not be necessary,", Kraerion said carefully, "It's a nice hollow, keep it dry and don't leave the wooden piece out of the door too often—that will erode the hollow faster."

"Oh, you don't have to *sell* it to me", Cash'ew laughed, "I'm not living in it, I'm leasing it out to a family of finches. Passive income, you know? You have to put your capital to work!"

"You're not living in it?", Kraerion said shocked, "How can that be, how can you afford that?"

"Wheeling and dealing in public procurement contracts has been—let's say—a quite lucrative endeavour recently.", the squirrel said, giving another chuckle, "It's business, I'll be wherever the opportunity arises. Anyhow, do we have a deal?"

Cash'ew raised his right paw for a shake. At first, a feeling of relief washed over Kraerion. No negotiation. But then, a creeping unease took its place. The squirrel was used to making deals; wouldn't he haggle? He had only spent a few screwnuts buying and building the hollow, and now—just like that—it was worth sixty leaves. Prices had gone up, sure, but this much? Wasn't this a bit too easy?

"Okay.", he finally mustered, reaching up his own paw, and they shook.

Kraerion hurried away from his former silver birch. He

didn't return to the Aorta, though. Instead, he made straight for the autumn market. With prices slowly rising, he reasoned, it felt prudent to spend it fast.

He didn't think much of what the market would look like, assuming it would be orderly and normal as usual. But, when he arrived there, it was absolute pandemonium. A pair of rabbits was frantically trying to out-bid each other over a measly basket of seemingly quite bruised apples. Everyone was desperate to quickly convert their leaves into something edible; the noise of haggling was deafening. He stood there in awe. "This is insane", he whispered to himself. His eyes wandered over the small signs; his jaw dropped when he grasped the prices.

"Hello, boss!", a young chipmunk Kraerion didn't recognize, greeted him. "Out buying groceries like a commoner?"

"Hi—, I'm sorry, I don't remember your name.", he said apologetically, "Sorry for asking, but how do you afford *anything* here? We don't pay this."

"No worries,", the chipmunk answered cheerfully, "We don't, me and a few in my scurry double-shift at the windmill construction."

"I see...", Kraerion said, although, he didn't really understand, "Hey listen, I'm glad I ran into you; I need to make a purchase and could use some help carrying it back to my office. could you run back to the Aorta and fetch a scurry for me?"

"Sure thing boss,", he squeaked, "you can count on me!"

As the young chipmunk scurried off, Kraerion turned his attention back at the stalls. He made a plan, he couldn't buy as much as he originally anticipated, but still enough for a comfortable winter. He scanned the prices again, "nothing fancy

then, only staple feed.", he thought, looking for the stall with the cheapest nuts. He pushed through the furred and feathered bodies, making his way to the back of the queue.

The line moved agonizingly slow. Directly in front of him stood a vole who was seemingly going through some sort of panic attack, muttering: "Please don't increase the prices... please don't increase the prices", over and over again.

Finally, he reached the front, finding a familiar face standing in the stall.

"Hi, Pip", Kraerion greeted. "I didn't know you worked the market."

"Oh, hi there Kraerion", the rat answered, "What can I say, it's a sign of the times. What can I help you with."

"Let's see", Kraerion began, "How much varied nuts can I get for sixty leaves?"

"We usually charge five leaves per bag", Pip said slowly, "Never mind, the chipmunk freight service have been a life saver. You really ought to increase your prices, but don't tell anyone I said that. For you, I can go down to four per bag. So for sixty—let's see—that would be fifteen bags."

"Great, thanks!", Kraerion replied, doing the mental calculation in his head. Fifteen bags would be more than enough for the winter, "There'll be a scurry here to pick it up shortly."

Kraerion left the market, the cacophony of angry voices and desperate haggling slowly fading away. The walk back to the Aorta wasn't far, so he tried to enjoy the little time he had above ground. Yet, his mind was a storm of conflicting thoughts.

Fifteen bags of real, tangible nuts. Cinnamon and the kits would be safe for the winter. He should be pleased; he

should feel a sense of triumph. Instead, he felt only an anxious knot tighten in his chest. *"You really ought to increase the prices."* Pip's words echoed in his ears. What about all the other chipmunks without assets to sell off? How many of the chipmunks in his workforce had other jobs just to get by? They were moving more cargo now then ever, yet somhow, the common chipmunk seemed worse off. He decided; he knew what he had to do.

His thoughts drifted to his father. Aequitius had passed away quietly in his sleep during the summer. Kraerion wished he was here now, so someone could tell him what to do. He hadn't appreciated his father in life as he did now in death, nor had he understood the enormous burden he carried. He smiled at the memory of him, grateful that he—at least—given the old chipmunk some solace before the end. "I lost a daughter...", he had said, "but, I got my son back."

Taking a deep breath, Kraerion entered the runs and headed down into the Aorta.

"Can someone fetch Pietus?" he called out to everyone, and to no one in particular, "Tell him to see me in my office."

He didn't wait for a response; he knew it would be done. Instead, he marched straight into his office—his father's old office—and shut the door.

Kraerion did not have to wait long before Pietus barged in to his office.

"What's the emergency?", Pietus asked, a hint of annoyance in his voice, "Why did you summon me? I've got work to do. The hedgehogs want to increase their shipments."

"At what price?", Kraerion demanded, glaring at his uncle. "Let me guess—the exact same rate we agreed to in the

spring?"

"Of course,", Pietus said curtly. "You know we don't discriminate. We've been over this—we can't just raise our prices."

"These agreements are ruining us. It's not discrimination, it's survival.", Kraerion argued, "Do you know how bad it is? Look at the market prices for feed! Our runners must take on extra shifts outside our employment, just to make ends meet. And, the public funding for the Winter Fund is ridiculous with today's prices, it's not nearly enough, are we supposed to just cover it ourselves? That—if anything—is discrimination."

"You know our bylaws, Kraerion", Pietus sighed, speaking as if he were arguing with a child. "We set our list prices in the spring, and then we're accountable for them. It's our duty to see it through."

"We are literally the only ones honoring any long-term price agreements. Our way of conducting business was set in a time before rapid price changes.", Kraerion cried, now desperate, "We have to renegotiate, that's our only option."

"No.", Pietus said with a finality in his voice, "We chipmunks have never broken an agreement, I refuse to be the first. Regardless if whether it's our list prices or our obligation to run the Winter Fund."

Before Kraerion had time to reply, the door to the office swung open. The young chipmunk he had met in at the market, and three other chipmunks, lugged the fifteen bags of nuts into the room.

"Where do you want them, boss?", the young chipmunk asked cheerfully.

Kraerion simply nodded to the corner of the office."Just put them over there...', he muttered. Then, realizing his tone

was quite unfair to the workers, he forced a smile, "Thanks for your swift service!"

The chipmunks did as they were bid, Pietus watching them hawkishly with a gaze full of suspicion. The four chipmunks left, pulling the door shut behind them.

"We're keeping feed in the office now?", Pietus accused, his eyes snapping back to his nephew. "You're out of line!"

"Oh, *I'm out of line?*", Kraerion countered mockingly, "It's feed I bought with my own leaves after selling my hollow, since no one—not even me—can support a family on the wages we pay."

"So, you're using our workers as your personal valet?", Pietus pressed, stepping closer.

"No, of course not.", Kraerion almost yelled, reddening from anger, "I'll pay, like anyone else. Not like it's much—we barely charge!"

"Have you forgotten,", Pietus asked, now suddenly appearing calm, "that in our agreement of funding for the Winter Fund, the leadership is held personally liable in case of a shortfall."

Kraerion froze. "You can't be serious—", Kraerion snapped. "What's that supposed to mean?"

"It means," Pietus said, "that a captain goes down with his ship, like any real leader would."

"You're really going to steal our feed? Starve your nephew's family?", Kraerion was fully yelling now; he could not believe what he was hearing, "You're going to kill us all!"

"If I must. We must lead by example; we must be the ones to starve first.", Pietus said somberly, "There's nothing you can do. You know you're in the wrong. Surrender the bags, Kraerion. Don't force me to involve the Crows."

The mention of the Crows—the implicit threat of their Stoats—snapped something deep inside Kraerion. This was not his uncle, this was a monster. His veil of civility fell, and left was only pure instinct. Kraerion took a couple of steps backwards, snatching up two heavy bags of nuts in his arms. Before his uncle could react, Kraerion rushed forward, dropping his shoulder, and tackled Pietus hard to the ground.

Panic seized him. "What have I done...?", he whispered, his voice wavering. He clutched the two bags closer to his chest and fled out of the office, sprinting blindly into the maze of runs.

Departure

"Hell is truth seen too late."

- Thomas Adam

The winter was mild, the snowfall light, and the usual biting cold had not blessed them with its presence. Yet, despite the winter's mercy, the animals died like fly larvae in drying puddles.

To a human, it could appear as though the forest were locked in a brutal civil war, heavy casualties mounting on both sides. But there were no armies, no heroic battles, and no weapons to be seen. The war was one of attrition against nutrition and cold, the enemy that of Nature. And, contrary to war, it's the meek that fall—the kits and the pups, and the old whose motor is not what it used to be.

Deep underground, below the warm snow-covered blanket, Kraerion crept through the silent runs. It was late evening, and most animals were already tucked in to keep their warmth. He moved with caution—his frame turned meager from the dearth of feed—in search of anything edible to steal. The chipmunk was a ghost of his former self; the once proud and moral being had reverted to a simple thief. But, in a way, he was still

the same chipmunk—what really is morality, when your kits are starving?

To Kraerion's surprise, he had been allowed to stay on as the logistics manager. But Pietus had taken every precaution to limit his access. His uncle had moved the Winter Fund's resources, and had him watched for most of the days. There was little solace in that, however; his wage was but a small defense against the Grim Reaper.

A noise down the run startled Kraerion. "Scat," he whispered to himself, pressing himself hard against the run's wall, holding his breath. The noise was coming closer, he had nowhere to go, nowhere to hide. He moved to the middle of the run, to appear less suspicious.

"Who's there?" someone called out, "I can hear you, show yourself!"

Kraerion sighed heavily. "It's just me, Kraerion", he called out.

A rat trotted up to him. "Oh, thank heaven," Pip sighed, "It's only you. Anyway, what are you doing here at this hour?"

"Erm", Kraerion mumbled to give himself some more time to think. "I'm... I'm just patrolling, making the rounds. We've had some thefts."

"You too!", Pip said, his face washing in relief. Kraerion's body relaxed; Pip did not suspect him. "We had someone steal nuts in the night, multiple times."

"Yes, I heard that," Kraerion lied, guilt rushing over him—he was, in fact, the thief. He needed to keep his cool. "Have you taken any measure against it?"

"We've instituted a neighbourhood watch program. Volunteers have signed up to keep guard," the rat explained. "It's my night tonight. Have the chipmunks done the same?"

"Yes, in a way...", Kraerion lied again. *"What was he going to do now?"*, his mind screamed. Although it pained him to steal from the rats that were no better off than himself, he *needed* that feed. "Anyway, have you seen anything suspicious tonight?"

"No, it's been quiet so far.", Pip said slowly, "Except you, of course."

The rat's expression changed slightly, his eyes narrowing. *"Had he been made?"*, Kraerion question himself with horror. Something in the chipmunk's conduct must have given him away; the rat looked very uncomfortable now.

"I, I think I should head back now," Pip said stumbling over his words, "I wish you a calm evening."

The rat left Kraerion alone with his thoughts. Panic seized him; his chest felt like it was going to explode. Pip knew. He pulled his knees to his chest, his meager body trembling. He had lost his dignity, and was yet to lose much more than that.

An image of his burrow flashed before him: Cinnamon, wrapping herself tightly around the kits, to share what little body heat she had left. He had failed them. Pip must already be on his way to tell the rest of the forest, to tell the Crows. There was nothing left for him to do. He forced himself back to his feet, a tear trickling down his snout.

The crushed chipmunk began to take the first steps back home. His mind spiraled, a haze of his long-lost dreams flashed before his eyes. His dear hollow, the beautiful sun. Everything he had sacrificed—sacrificed just to lose it all. Cinnamon and himself might still survive, their remaining body fat keeping them alive—but not the kits. They had not had time to accumulate any fat. And, even if he did survive, what would

happen to him next? A life in exile?

Suddenly, voices appeared in the dark, followed by a vague light. Kraerion looked up, not recognizing where he was. He had, for the first time in his life, become lost in the runs. This must be a recently built run, a very narrow one at that. Regardless, he followed it towards the voices.

The run widened, and eventually he exited into a massive hall. The ceiling and walls were covered with bright lights, *"it must be some kind of glow-worms, trapped somehow,"* Kraerion thought. The walls of the hall was covered in gorgeous wooden paneling, that must have been carved by a skilled woodpecker. Around the glow-worms, set with equal spacing, sat decorative screw-nuts fastened, in a mezmerizing recursive pattern.

His eyes slowly adjusted to the lights, and he saw Crows, Magpies, and a few other animals. They were all eating and laughing around a big oaken table. He wittnesed a feast of excess, and his mouth watered. This must be directly below the Old Oak, he realized. This was what he had witnessed that wonderful summer day with Cinnamon, back when life was still beautiful.

A crow must have noticed him standing there. "Hello there, Kraerion!", he cawed. "Don't be shy!"

The bird was moving towards him now. Kraerion saw, to his surprise, that it was Hroðulf.

"Why the long face?" Hroðulf exclaimed.

"What is this place...?" Kraerion said astounded, ignoring the question entirely.

"Oh, this?", Hroðulf began, gesturing with his wing. "It's the Twig's round table, where all the major decisions are made. A bit much, isn't it?"

"I've never seen anything like it," Kraerion answered, "A bit much doesn't begin to cover it."

"Yes, my point exactly!", the crow hooted cheerfully. "But, we saved the Forest! And if the comfort of this room makes our decisions get only one percent better, it's all worth it."

"Excuse me," Kraerion said in absolute disbelief. "Saved the Forest? Do I look *saved* to you?"

"Ah, you're confusing anecdotes with empirical evidence," Hroðulf smirked. "It's a common mistake; don't feel too bad. We've measured the Gross Forest Yield, and the average animal has spent more leaves this year than ever before. Even if you adjust for the loss in purchasing power, the velocity of trade more than makes up for it. The forest is richer now than it ever has been."

"But, what about us... all our hard work?" Kraerion couldn't stop the tears from falling now. "How come you wouldn't fund the Winter fund more?"

"Good question!" Hroðulf praised, speaking as if he were lecturing a child. "I would argue that public must have great negotiators since they're representing the interests of the whole forest. They must be as ferocious with the public's leaves, as if they were their own."

The bird took a pause, tapping his beak thoughtfully, "And in your personal case... I'm quite surprised you chipmunks chose Pietus to represent your interests. He's a slave to virtue, that one. A very naive and poor economic steward, truth be told."

"But, what about the windmill." Kraerion looked around, seeing the luxurious hall through his tears, "and this place, you did not spare the public here, did you?"

"Ah, that is very different," Hroðulf said warmly. "The

Forest was in a tough place. Many an animal was unemployed. We needed more jobs so that the animals got leaves to spend again, which in turn would stimulate the economy. You chipmunks were already fully employed. And, while I'm not fond of vanity projects—especially dumb ones like the windmill; where would we even get the wheat from?—they *do* create jobs. I would even go so far as to support a project where we dig a massive hole, just to fill it back up again, so long as it adds jobs to the Forest."

The Crow took another pause, a proud smile spreading across his beak. "And with the result in hand, unemployment is almost non-existent. We must conclude that the windmill was a resounding success!"

Something finally clicked in Kraerion. He understood that he didn't understand—that he would never understand. That was his fatal flaw.

The chipmunk left Hroðulf and the feast without saying another word. He walked blindly back through the narrow run, eventually finding a path out to the biting cold and free, unadulterated air. The night was quiet, the stars told of a world still beautiful. After all that hard work, and all that pain, he deserved some rest. *"At least the cold is real."* he thought; a thought that would be his last. He curled up in the snow beneath the roots of a grand spruce, closed his eyes, and finally found peace.

Death is not the opposite of life, just as ignorance is not the opposite of knowledge—it's merely a lack thereof.

If you had asked Kraerion at the beginning of this tale what the opposite of life was, he would have answered with-

out hesitation, with his back straight, and his head held high: *to not have lived*. To be but a passenger while life passes by; to leave the proverbial marrow left unsucked. And if *to live* is the answer to life, then spelling it backwards reveals another answer.

Whatever the opposite of life might be, we know this to be true: Kraerion did die, but he never lost his life; he had but no life left to lose.

THE END